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NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 Montana Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **18 in every 100**, mark the international share of Montana's STEM master's degrees.



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By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

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A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 20
Section 3 Where Students Come From 26
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 34
Section 5 Graduate Research 36
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 38
Section 7 Research Funding 40
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 42
Section 9 STEM Workforce 46
Section 10 Patents 48
Section 11 Competitors 50
Section 12 Fields of Study 52
Section 13 Students and Money 62
Section 14 Student Outcomes 70
Section 15 Faculty 74
Section 16 Institutions 78

BACK MATTER

About these Data 82
By the Numbers 84
Sources 93

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Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to Montana: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

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Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from federal sources: the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, as the backbone, together with NAEP, NSF's surveys of graduate students, doctorates and research funding, USAspending.gov, DHS and ICE SEVIS data, the Department of Labor, USCIS, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, and USPTO PatentsView. Each figure names its source, and the Sources page lists all of them. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 Montana Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What Montana's numbers say

1. **International students earn 18% of Montana's STEM master's degrees,** 34.2 points below the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 45th of 51 on dependence. The share is 12% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 1.2% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **Montana awarded 56 STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 0.0% of the U.S. total and 46th of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed 2.3×, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in engineering,** where international students earned 20% of master's degrees (74 degrees; U.S. 49%). No STEM field with at least 50 master's graduates are majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** Montana ranks 4th of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: Montana 18%, North Dakota 36%, South Dakota 48%, Delaware 72%, Vermont 9.6%.
5. **58% of Montana's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 0.9% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (3.5K) than residents left (2.01K), a net gain of 1.48K; the top destination for those leaving was North Dakota.

18%

of the STEM master's degrees Montana awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

48.4K #48
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · −4.8% since 2015

56 #46
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K**

18% #45
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +9.2 pp since 2015

6.4% #45
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +0.2 pp since 2015

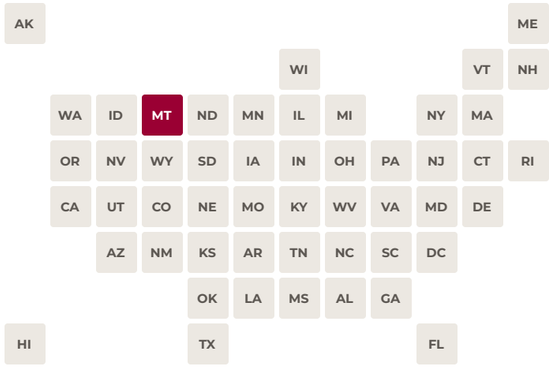
32% #3
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +5.8 pp since 2015

52% #49
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +6.7 pp since 2015

$9.29K #36
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +11% since 2015

58% #42
First-time students from in state, 2024
−6.8 pp since 2016

$82K #43
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −4.3% since 2016



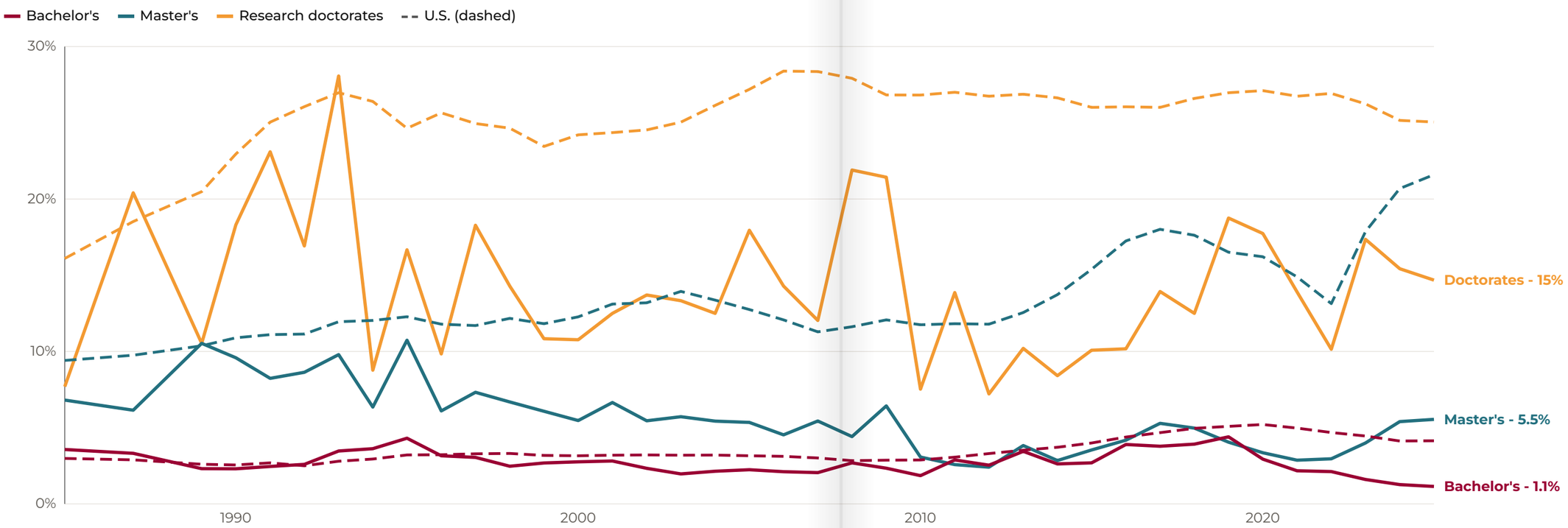
Badges give Montana's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

Montana ranks 46th of 51 on the international share of all master's, at 5.5% in 2025 against 22% for the U.S.

Figure 1 What Share of Montana's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025.

International students make up 6.4% of Montana's graduate enrollment and 1.1% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 1.1% of bachelor's, 5.5% of master's and 15% of research doctorates go to international students.

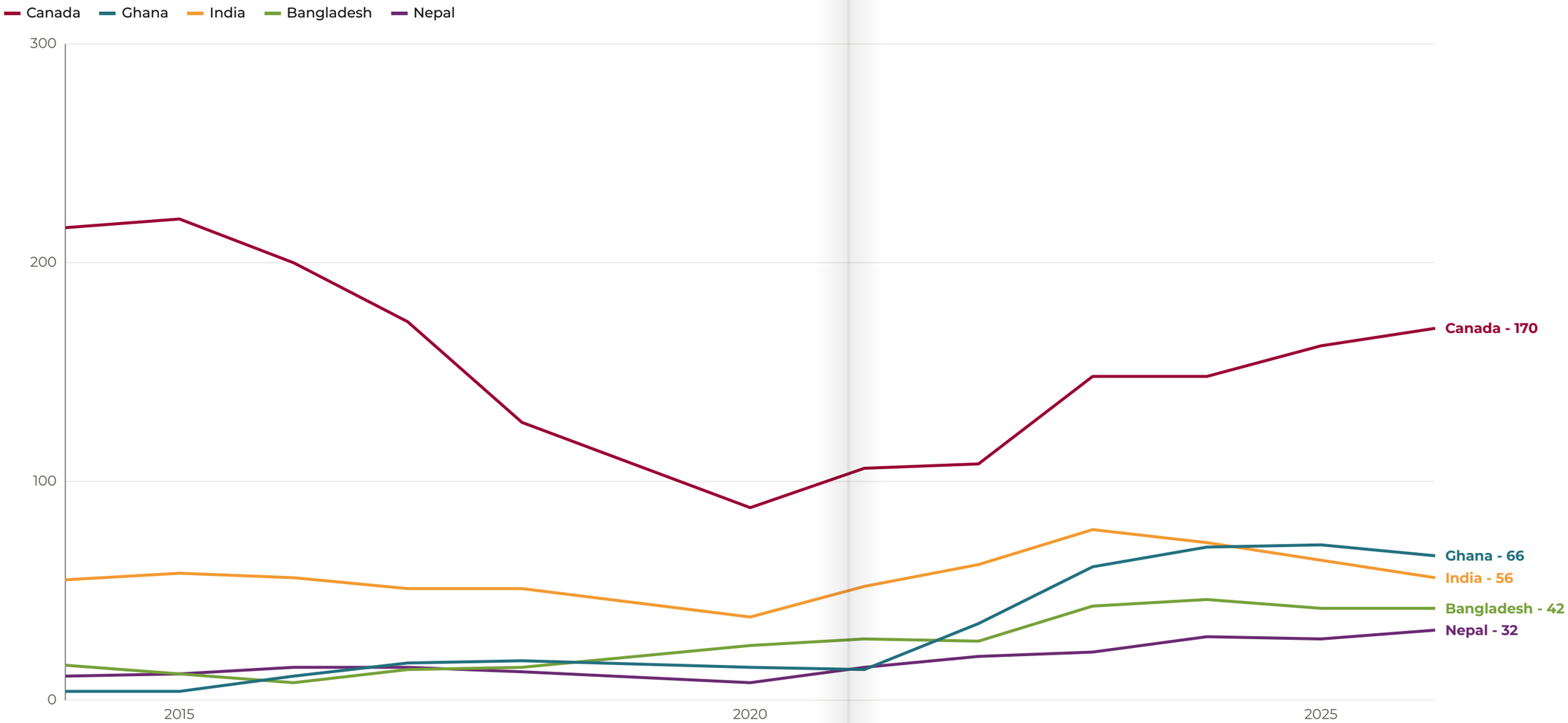
In STEM the shares are higher still: 1.2% of STEM bachelor's, 18% of STEM master's and 12% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 0.0% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 46th of 51.

6.4%
Int. share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · **45th** of 51 · +0.2 pp since 2015

5.5%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **46th** of 51 · +2.0 pp since 2015

18%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **45th** of 51 · +9.2 pp since 2015

Figure 2 Where Do Montana's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

In October 2026, Montana had 849 active international students in SEVIS, 50th of 51. Canada accounted for 20% of them and Ghana for 7.8%, against 3.3% and 1.3% nationally.

Students came from 89 countries, but the two largest supplied 28%. The state's total is down 50% since 2015, when it stood at 1.68K.

849
Active international students, October 2026
50th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

20%
From Canada
U.S. **3.3%**

56%
In STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

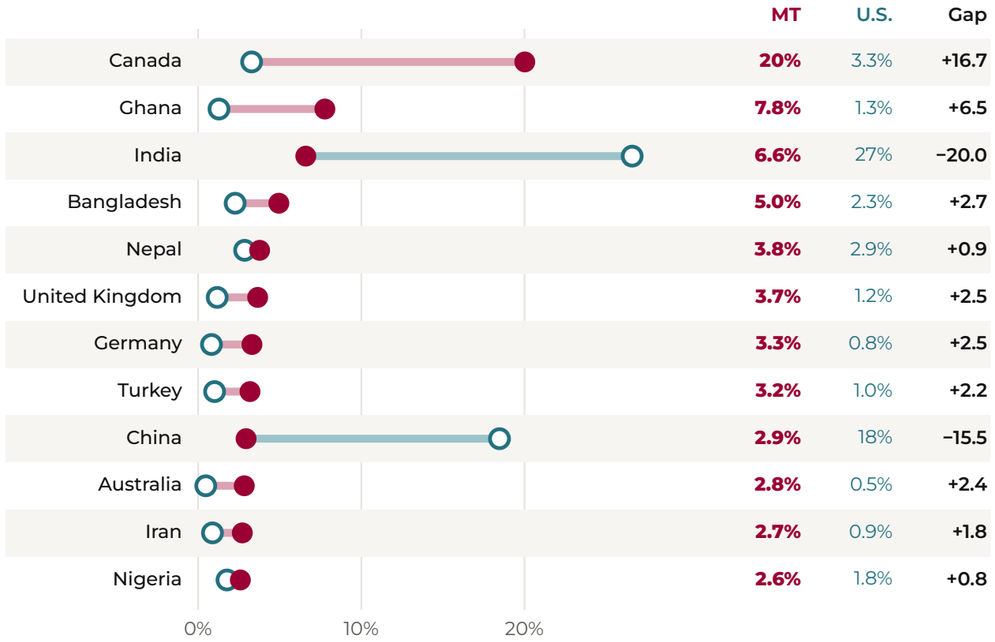
How Does Montana's Mix of Countries Compare With the Nation's?

In October 2026, Montana had **849** active F-1 and M-1 students, 50th among the 50 states and DC and **0.1%** of the U.S. total. They came from 89 countries.

Canada supplied **20%** of them, against 3.3% nationally, and Ghana **7.8%**, against 1.3%. India (6.6%), Bangladesh (5.0%), and Nepal (3.8%) followed.

Together the two largest countries supplied **28%** of the state's international students (U.S. 45%), 39th among the states, against 38% in 2015.

Figure 3 Is Montana's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

849
Active international students, October 2026
50th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

20%
From Canada
U.S. **3.3%**

7.8%
From Ghana
U.S. **1.3%**

89
Countries represented
U.S. **219**

The state's count is down 1.8% from 2025 and down 50% since 2015, when it stood at 1.68K. Its share of all U.S. international students is down 0.1 points since 2015, to **0.1%**.

Since 2015, the number of students from Canada went from 220 to 170, Ghana's from 4 to 66, and India's from 58 to 56.

Over the same years, the number from Bangladesh went from 12 to 42 and Nepal's from 12 to 32. The table gives each country's count for the first, previous and latest years.

Table 1 International Students in Montana, 2015–2026

	2015	2025	2026	Change since 2015	U.S. 2026	Rank
ALL INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS						
Active F-1 and M-1 students	1.68K	865	**849**	−50%	1.19M	50th
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.1%	0.1%	**0.1%**	−0.1 pp	–	50th
Countries of citizenship represented	103	94	**89**	−14%	219	50th
Share from the two largest countries of origin	38%	27%	**28%**	−10.2 pp	45%	39th
LARGEST COUNTRIES OF CITIZENSHIP (STUDENTS)					**U.S. SHARE**	**STATE SHARE**
Canada	220	162	**170**	−23%	3.3%	20%
Ghana	4	71	**66**	–	1.3%	7.8%
India	58	64	**56**	−3.4%	27%	6.6%
Bangladesh	12	42	**42**	–	2.3%	5.0%
Nepal	12	28	**32**	–	2.9%	3.8%

Active F-1 and M-1 students, one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November; 2019 has none; the latest year is October 2026). Rank among the 50 states and DC. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

Figure 4

Which Countries Supply Montana's International STEM Students?

478 of Montana's international students were in STEM fields in October 2026, **56%** of the total against 63% nationally, down 43% since 2015.

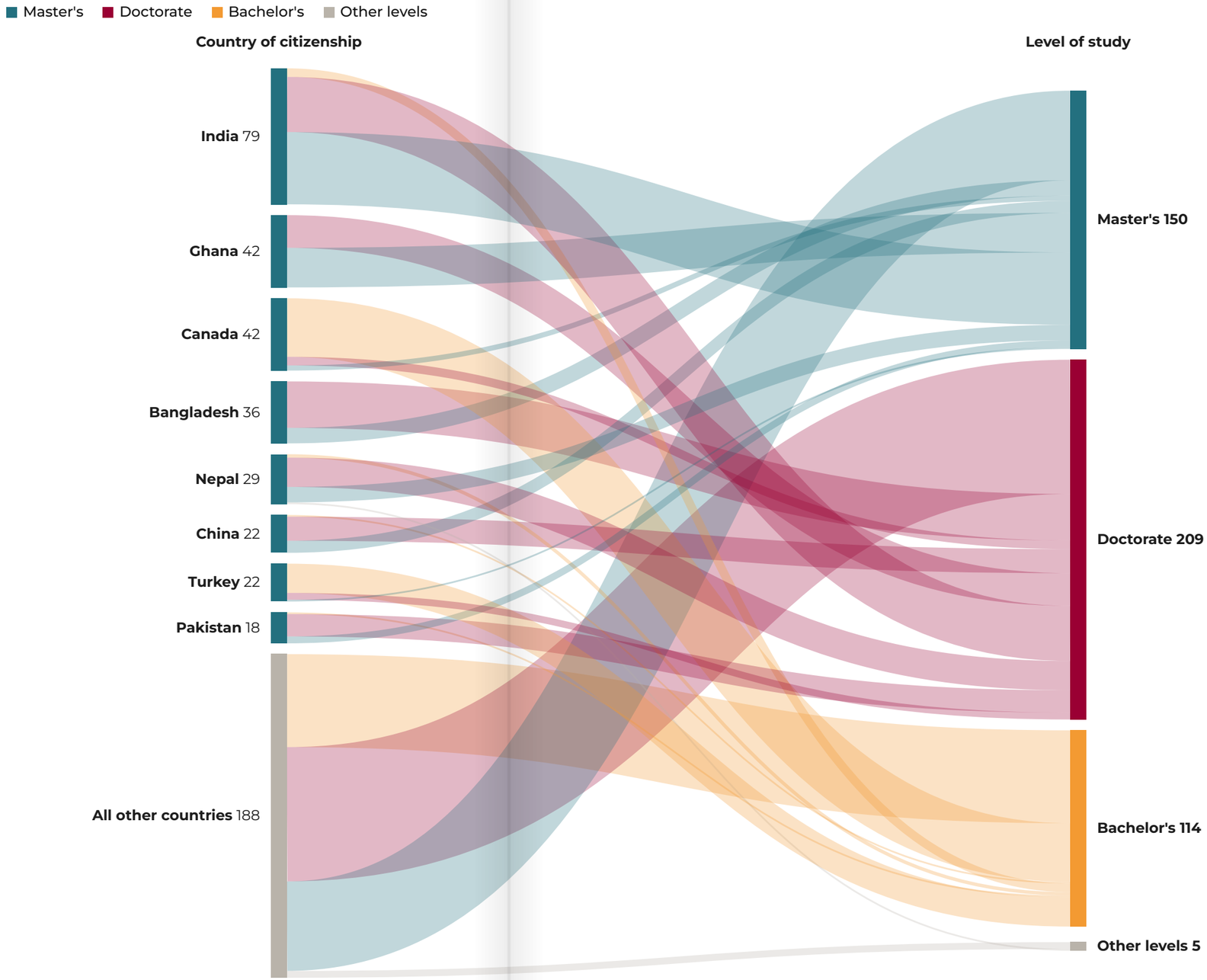
Doctoral students were the largest group, **209**. India supplied 15% of them and Bangladesh 13%.

STEM doctoral students went from 93 in 2015 to **209**, and STEM master's students from 77 to 150.

478
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students, 2026
U.S. **749K** · **50th** of 51 · −43% since 2015

56%
Share in STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

150
Active STEM master's students, 2026
U.S. **393K** · **49th** of 51 · +95% since 2015



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship and level of study, October 2026; the eight largest countries are shown. DHS does not draw its STEM pages on the same basis as its all-student pages, so the STEM count here exceeds the all-level count for India (79 against 56). Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

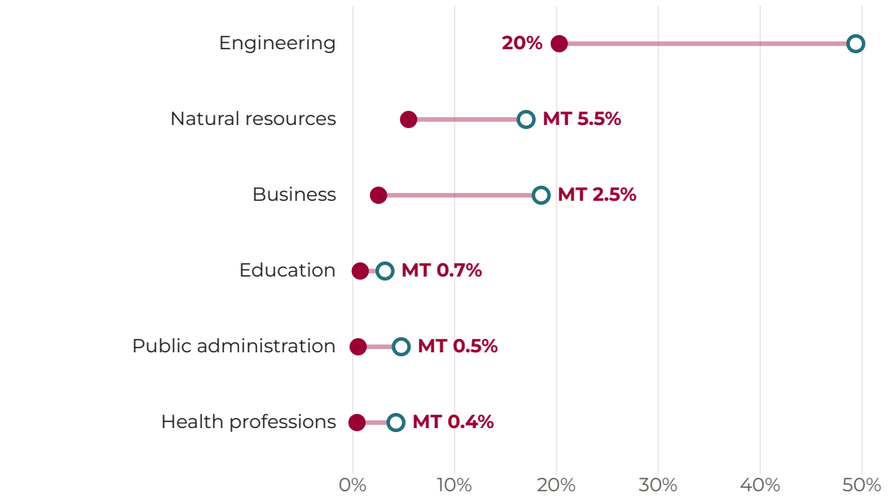
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How International Are Montana's Master's Fields?

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in Montana in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

Highest international shares. International students earned the largest shares of master's degrees in engineering (20%, against 49% for the U.S.), natural resources (5.5%, against 17% for the U.S.), and business (2.5%, against 19% for the U.S.).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

5.5%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **46th** of 51

18%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **45th** of 51

20%
Int. share of engineering & eng. technology master's, 2025
U.S. **50%** · **45th** of 50

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: Montana first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

Highest international share among STEM master's fields. International students earned 20% of the master's degrees in engineering, against 49% for the U.S.

Table 2 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	0.5% / 8.6%	**48% / 65%**	– / 56%
Engineering	2.5% / 7.2%	**20% / 49%**	22% / 55%
Engineering technology	0.0% / 4.5%	**– / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	0.0% / 17%	**26% / 55%**	– / 53%
Physical sciences	0.8% / 6.0%	**27% / 33%**	13% / 38%
Biological sciences	1.1% / 3.4%	**18% / 23%**	10% / 23%
Natural resources	0.3% / 2.0%	**5.5% / 17%**	5.0% / 27%
Architecture	1.5% / 7.3%	**0.0% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in Montana / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

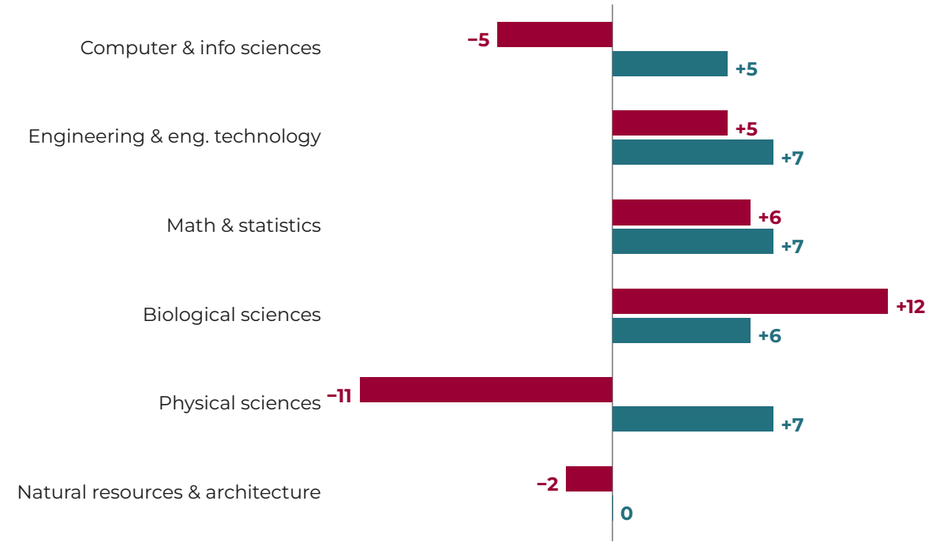
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How Has Montana's STEM Master's Output Grown?

Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Montana between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

STEM master's degrees. The state awarded 312 in 2025 and 275 in 2015, a change of +32 for international students and +5 for domestic students.

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

56
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · **46th** of 51

22%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **23rd** of 51

0.0%
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025
46th of 51

2.9
STEM master's per STEM research doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **45th** of 51

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Montana in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

STEM share of master's degrees. The share was 22% in 2025, against 23% for the U.S., 23rd among the states, down 2.1 points from 24% in 2024 and up 0.7 points since 2015, when it was 21%.

Table 3 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	21	**21**	–	10	–	–
Engineering & eng. technology	62	**74**	+19%	15	13%	20%
Math & statistics	29	**42**	–	11	–	26%
Biological sciences	15	**33**	–	6	–	18%
Physical sciences	41	**37**	–	10	7.3%	27%
Natural resources & architecture	107	**105**	−1.9%	4	3.7%	3.8%

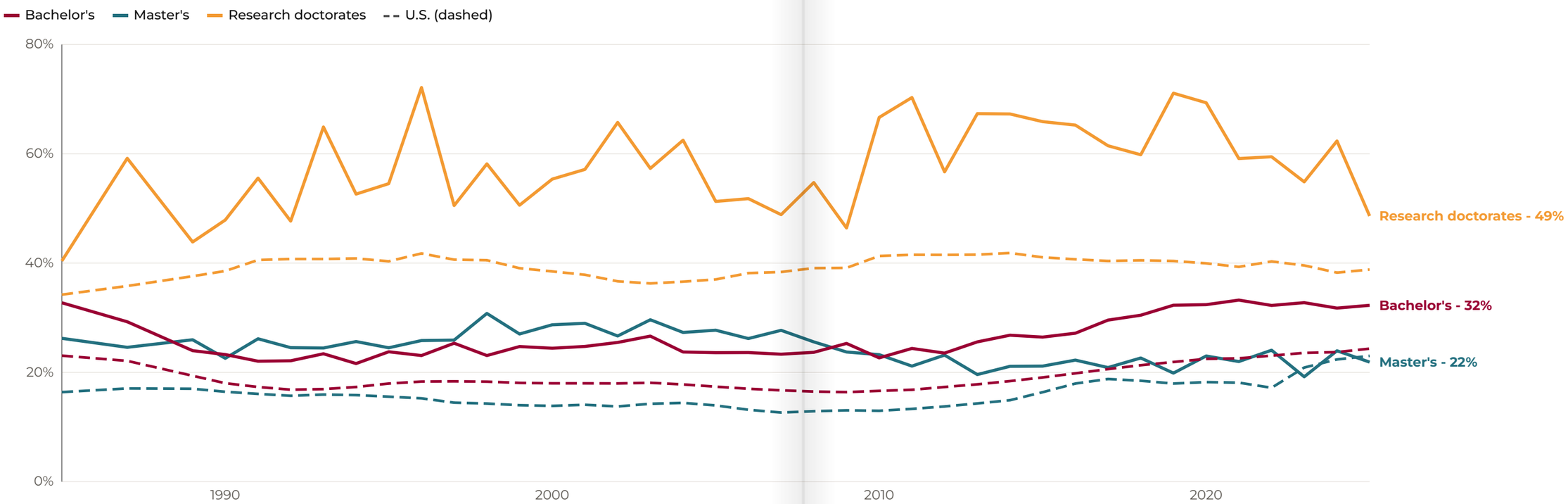
STEM master's degrees awarded in Montana, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

Montana ranks 3rd of 51 on the STEM share of bachelor's, at 32% in 2025 against 24% for the U.S.

Figure 7 How Much of Montana's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 32% of Montana's bachelor's degrees, 22% of its master's and 49% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 0.7 points since 2015, and the state ranks 23rd of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 3rd of 51.

32%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **3rd** of 51 · +5.8 pp since 2015

22%

STEM share of master's, 2025

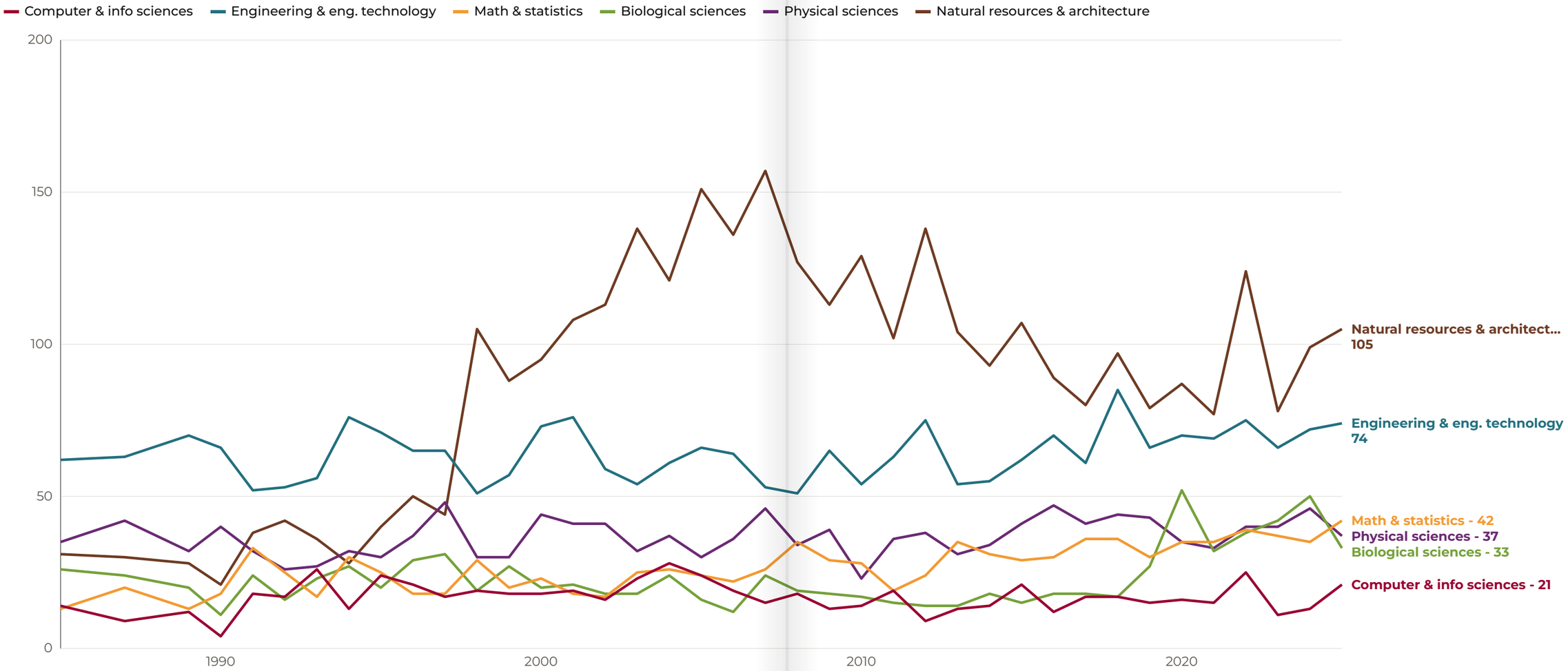
U.S. **23%** · **23rd** of 51 · +0.7 pp since 2015

49%

STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **13th** of 51 · −17.3 pp since 2015

Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce Montana's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Natural resources & architecture produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 105, followed by engineering & eng. technology (74) and math & statistics (42). Master's degrees in natural resources & architecture are roughly flat since 2015.

International students earned 56 of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 0.0% of the national total (46th of 51).

56

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **46th** of 51

0.0%

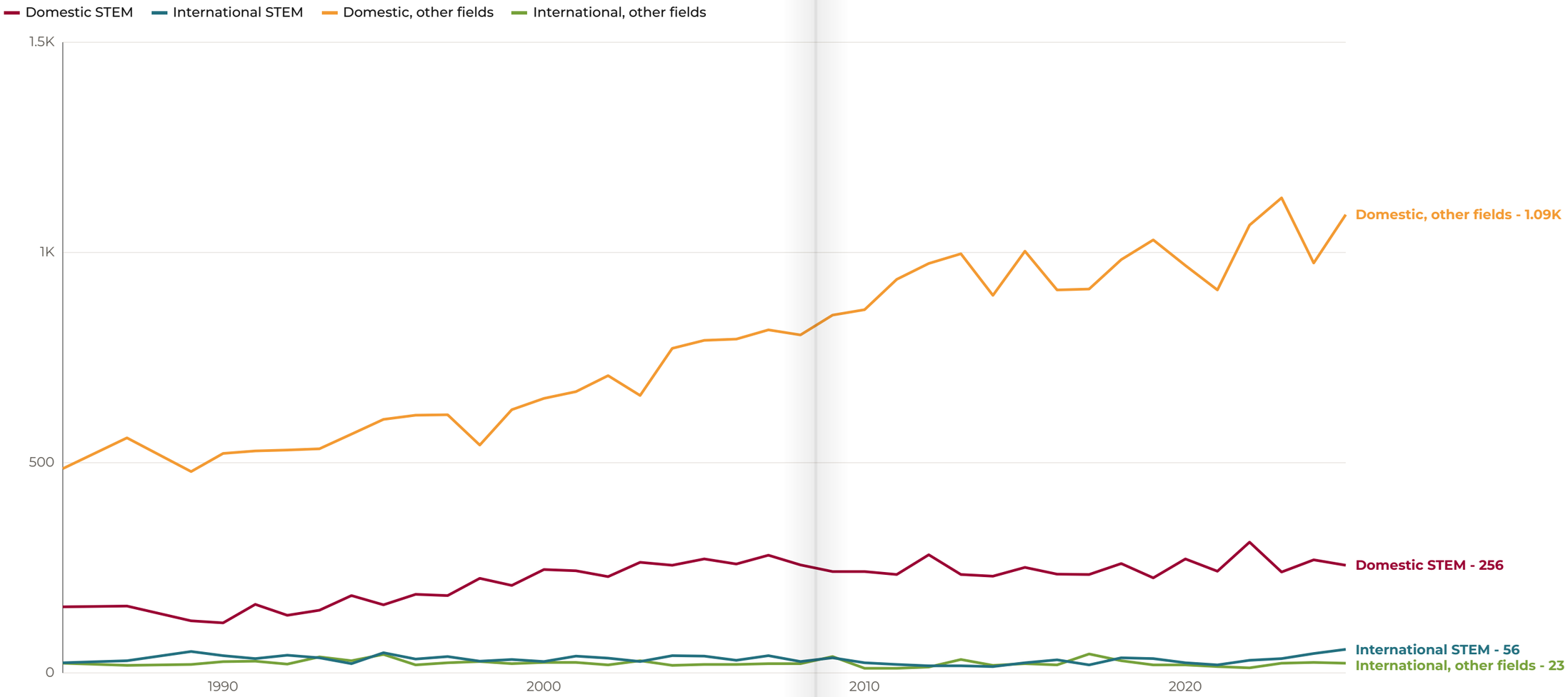
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

46th of 51 · 0.0 pp since 2015

–

Int. share of CS master's, null

Figure 9 Who Earns Montana's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 32 more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 5 more to domestic students.

International students earn 18% of Montana's STEM master's but 2.1% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).

5.5%

Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **46th** of 51 · +2.0 pp since 2015

18%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **45th** of 51 · +9.2 pp since 2015

2.9

STEM master's per STEM research doctorate (IPEDS), 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **45th** of 51 · −0.3 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

Montana ranks 48th of 51 on the share of first-time students whose home is outside the US, at 0.9% in 2024 against 3.1% for the U.S.

Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest sources and destinations (more when states tie at the printed figure), the rest grouped; ties are ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

5.15K residents stayed in Montana for college in fall 2024; 3.5K students arrived from other states and 77 from abroad, while 2.01K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 58% of the state's first-time students are residents.

58%

First-time students from in state, 2024

42nd of 51 · −6.8 pp since 2016

0.9%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

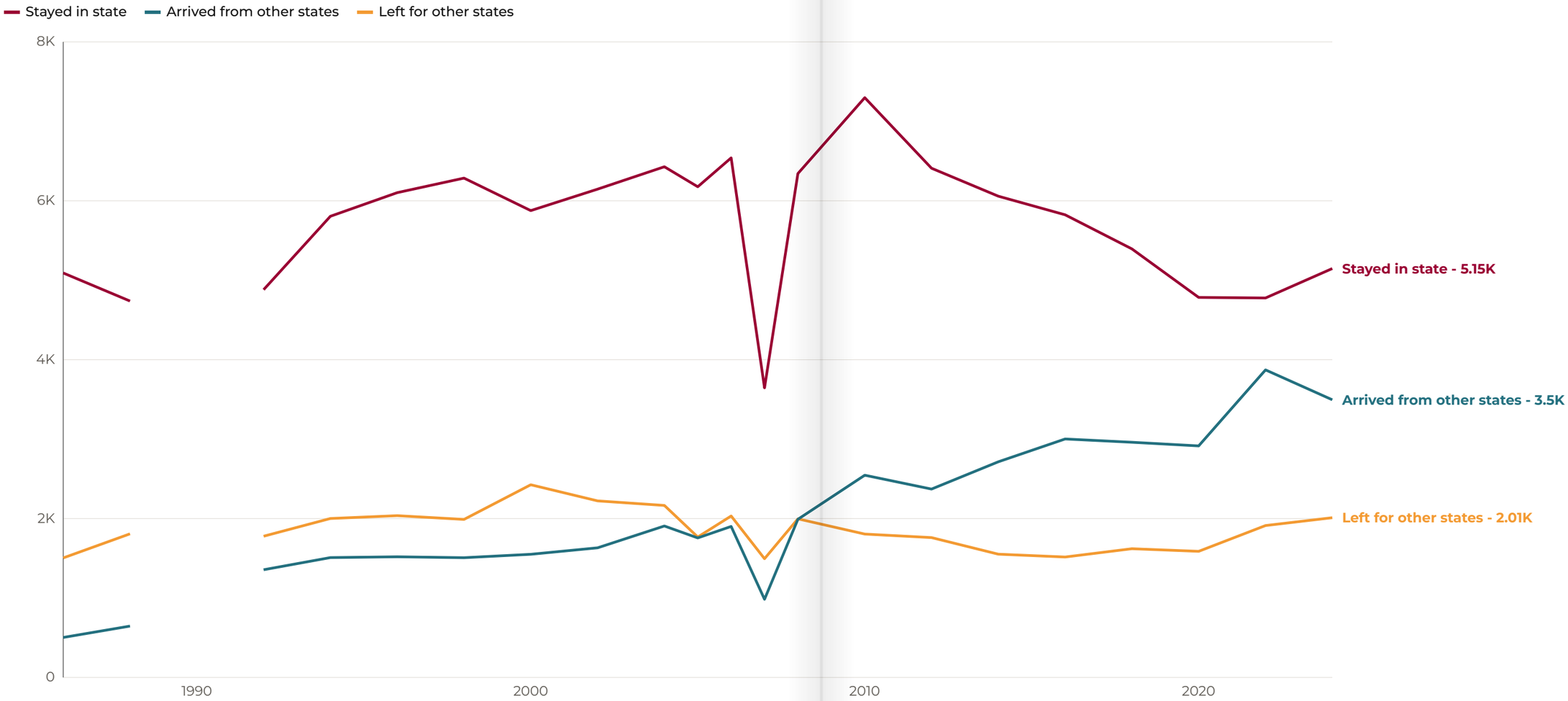
U.S. **3.1%** · **48th** of 51 · −0.4 pp since 2016

+21

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

13th of 51 · +0.5 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is down 12%, arrivals from other states are up 16%, and residents leaving are up 33%.

Net migration was +21 per 100 resident first-time students (13th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was North Dakota (209).

Figure 12

Where Do Montana's Newcomers Come From?

The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at Montana's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

3.57K

First-time students from other states and abroad, fall 2024

Abroad **77**

0.9%

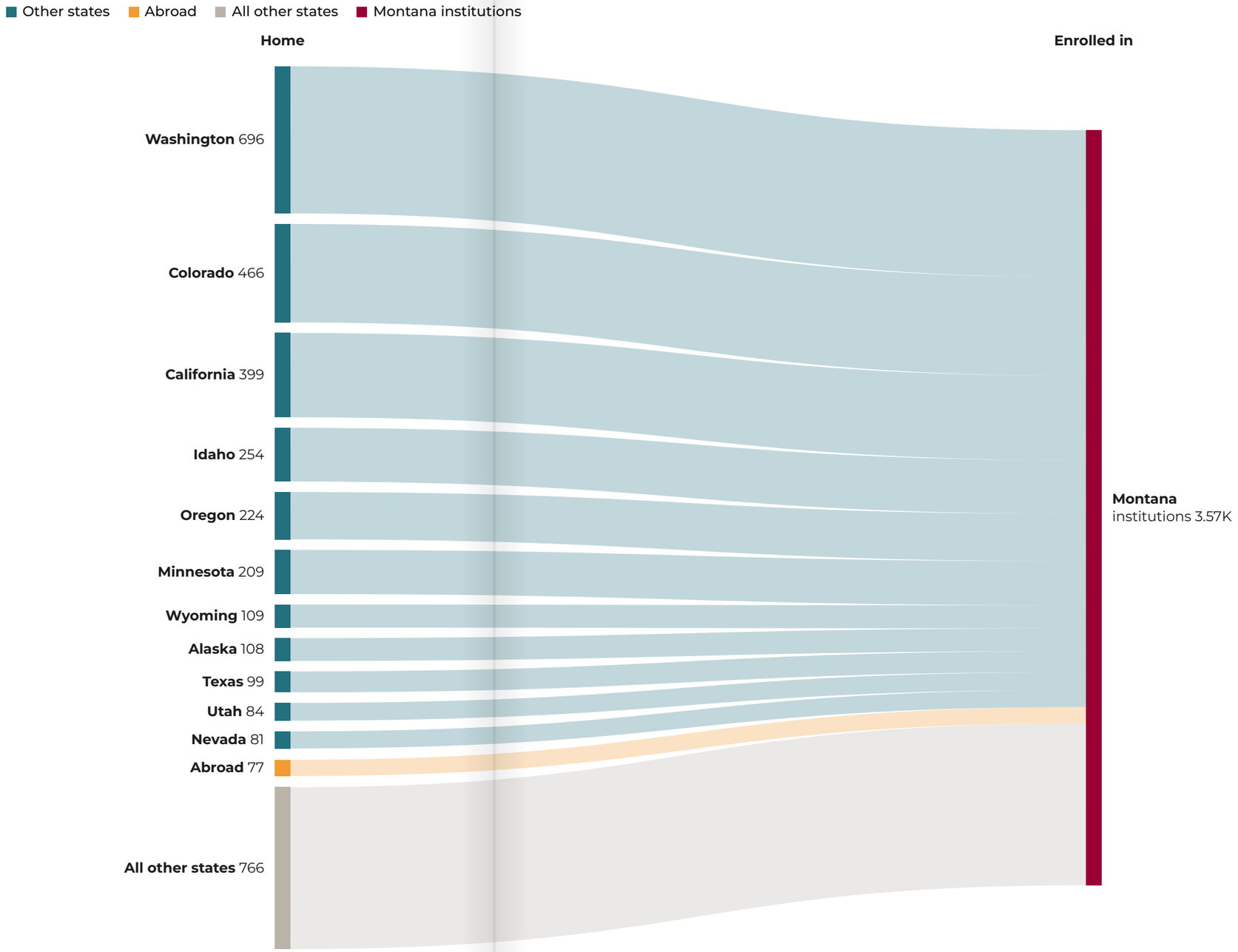
First-time students from abroad, 2024

U.S. **3.1%** · **48th** of 51 · −0.4 pp since 2016

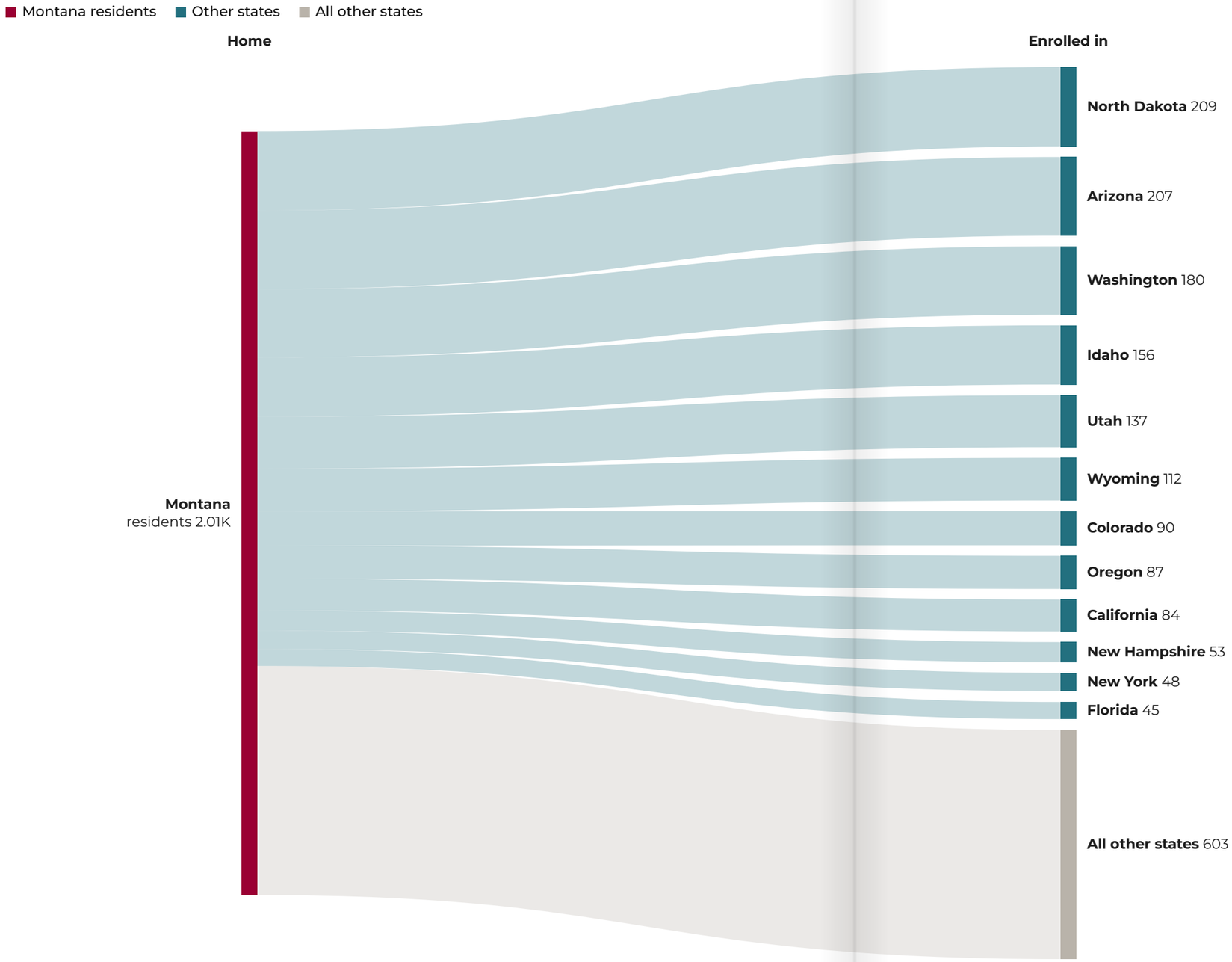
58%

First-time students from in state, 2024

42nd of 51 · −6.8 pp since 2016



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Figure 13

Where Do Montana's Residents Go When They Leave?

The bands show where Montana residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

Residents leaving for other states. The number was 2.01K in fall 2024, up 5.2% from 1.91K in fall 2022 and up 33% since fall 2016, when it was 1.52K.

2.01K
Residents who started college in another state, fall 2024
Arrived from other states **3.5K** · **3.57K** with abroad

+21
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024
13th of 51 · +0.5 since 2016

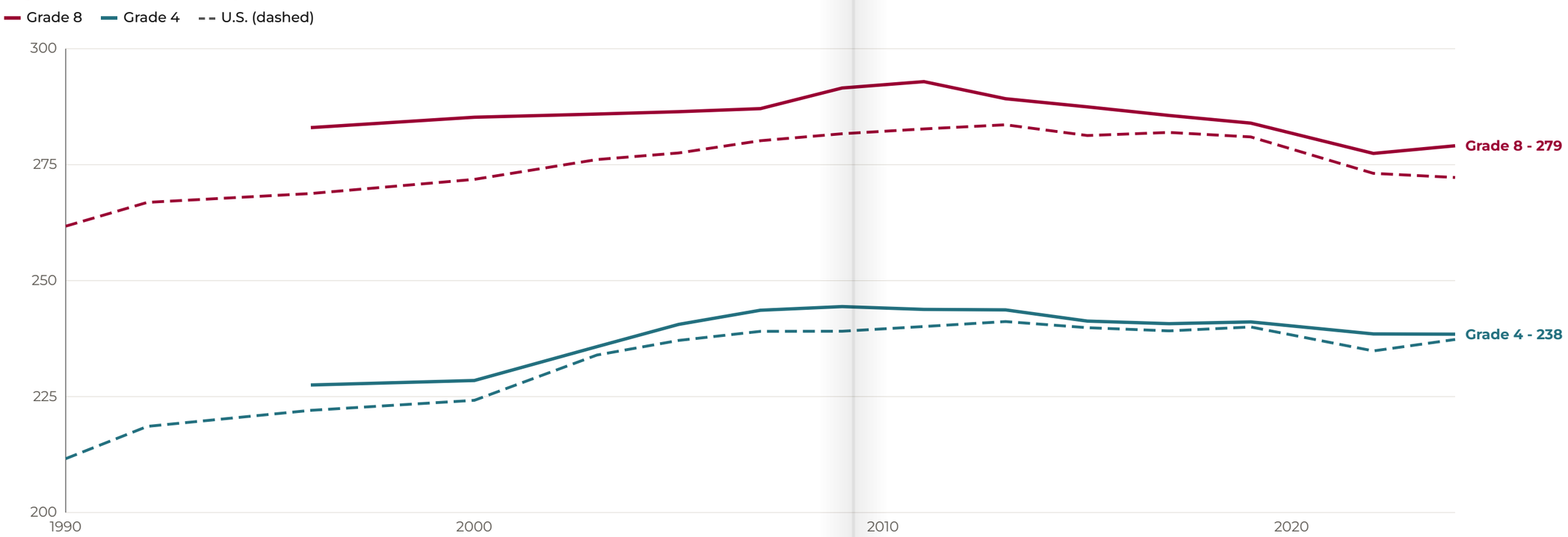
209
Went to North Dakota
The largest destination

SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

Montana ranks 10th of 51 on the average grade 8 mathematics score, at 279 in 2024 against 272 for the U.S.

Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are Montana's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, National Assessment of Educational Progress.

The talent pipeline starts in school. Montana's eighth graders averaged 279 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 10th of 51 among the states.

32% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.

279

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **10th** of 51 · −8.4 since 2015

32%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **10th** of 51 · −6.8 pp since 2015

261

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

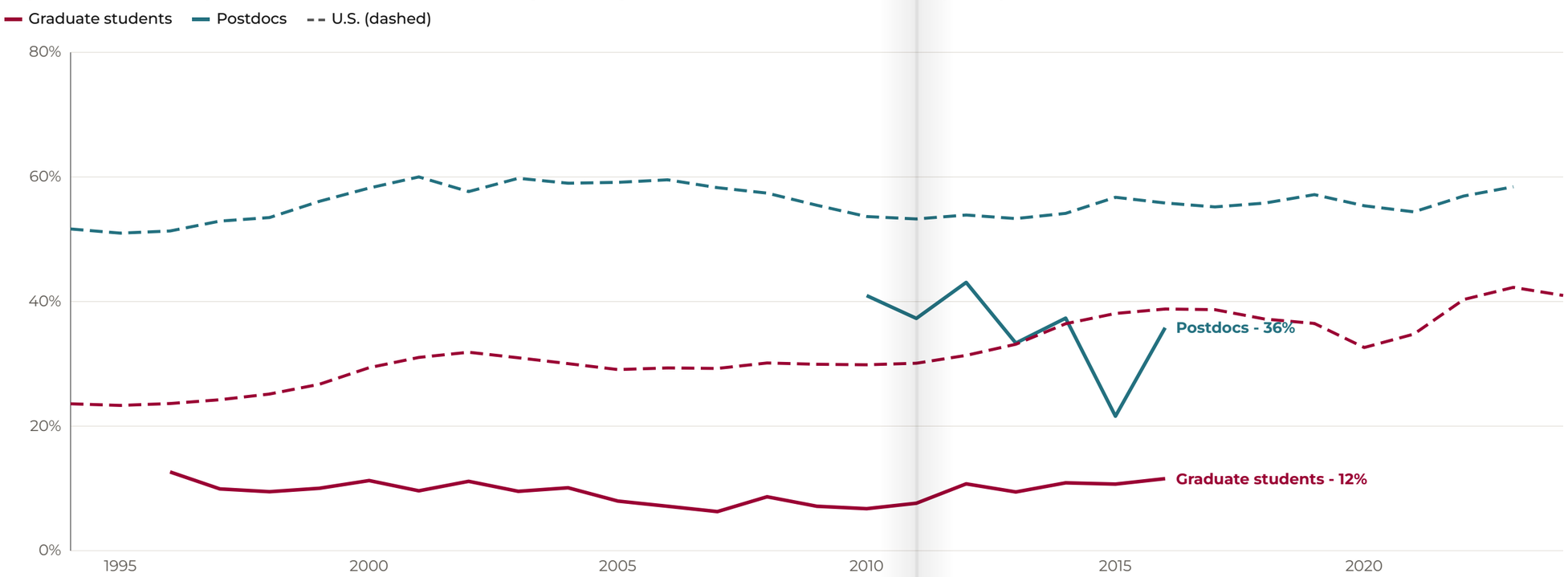
U.S. **257** · **11th** of 51 · −9.4 since 2015

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Montana ranks 51st of 51 on the temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students, at 12% in 2016 against 39% for the U.S.

Figure 15 How Many of Montana's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Temporary Visas?



Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's state; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 12% of Montana's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 51st of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 36% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 151 research doctorates in 2025, 0.3% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

12%

S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **39%** · **51st** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

36%

S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **56%** · **48th** of 51 · +14.2 pp since 2015

151

Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025

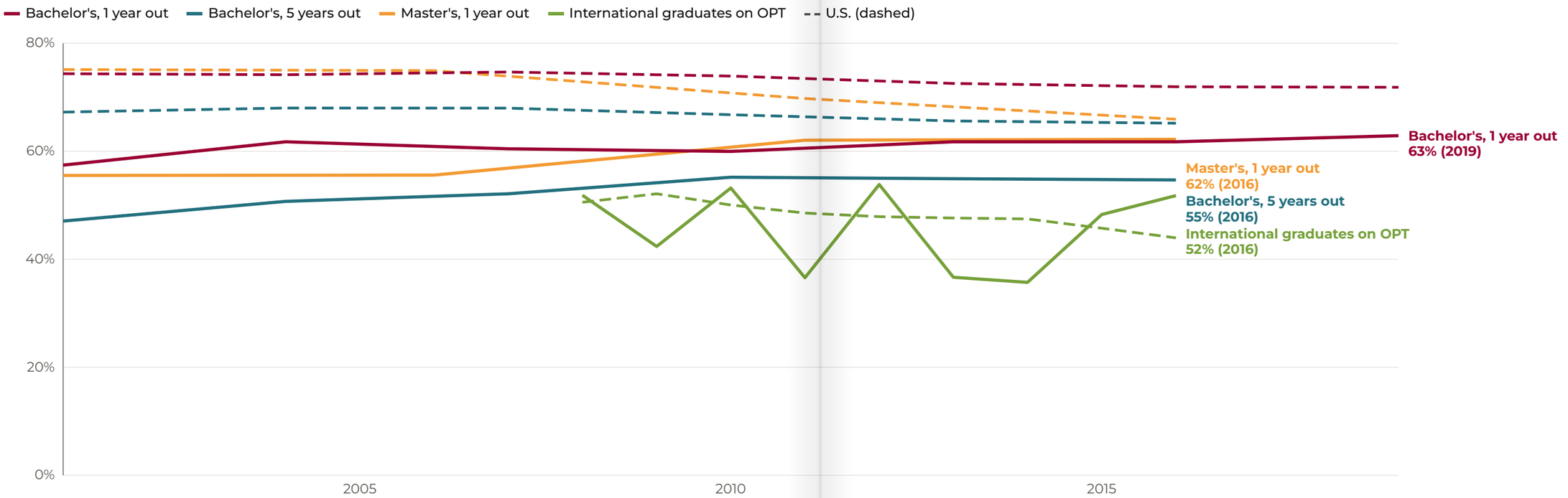
U.S. **59K** · **45th** of 51 · +18% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

Montana ranks 8th of 51 on the share of international graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied, at 52% in 2016 against 44% for the U.S.

Figure 16 How Many of Montana's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?



Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or participating states dashed.

Of Montana's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 63% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 55%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 52% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). That is the last year the released records cover, before most of the growth in international STEM master's degrees since 2015. Through migration between states, the state gained 1.8 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

63%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **20th** of 33 · +1.1 pp since 2016

52%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **8th** of 51 · +3.5 pp since 2015

+1.8

Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

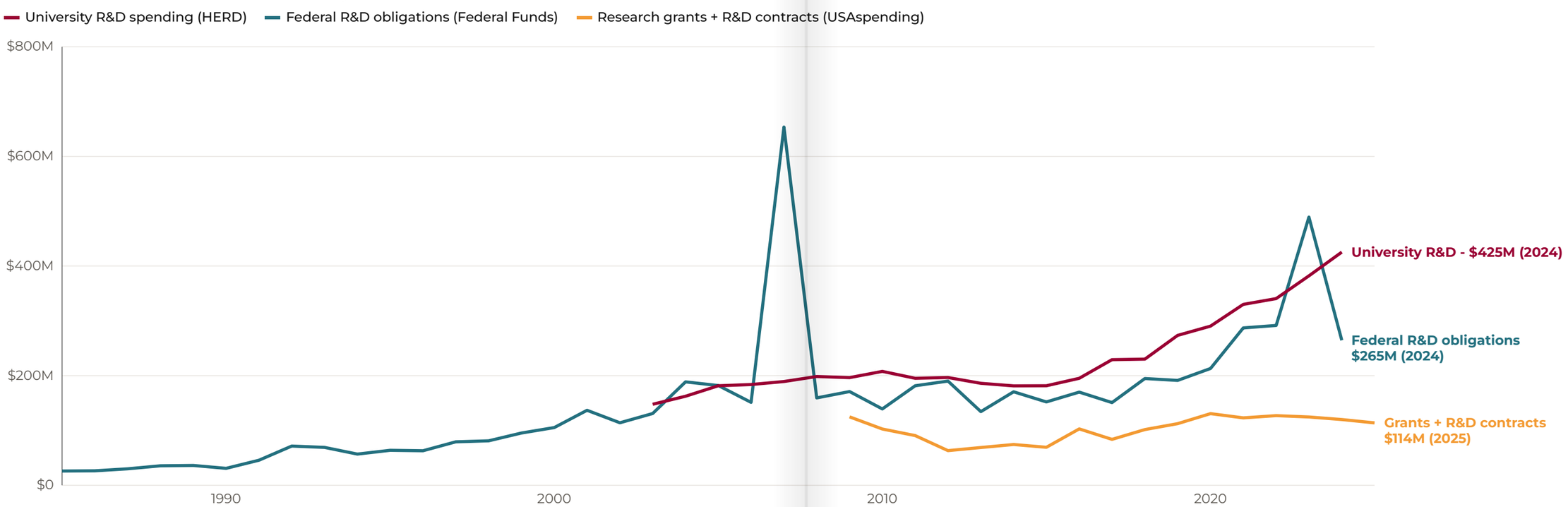
22nd of 51 · −10.7 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Montana ranks 46th of 51 on federal R&D obligations to the state, at $265M in 2024 against $193B for the U.S.

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into Montana?



Nominal dollars (not adjusted for inflation), fiscal years; a line ending before the others is labeled with its last year. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Development Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D contracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

Montana's universities spent $425M on research and development in FY2024, 41st of 51 among the states; 62% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $265M for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

$425M
University R&D spending, 2024
U.S. **$118B** · **41st** of 51 · 2.34× since 2015

62%
Federal share of university R&D, 2024
U.S. **55%** · **9th** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

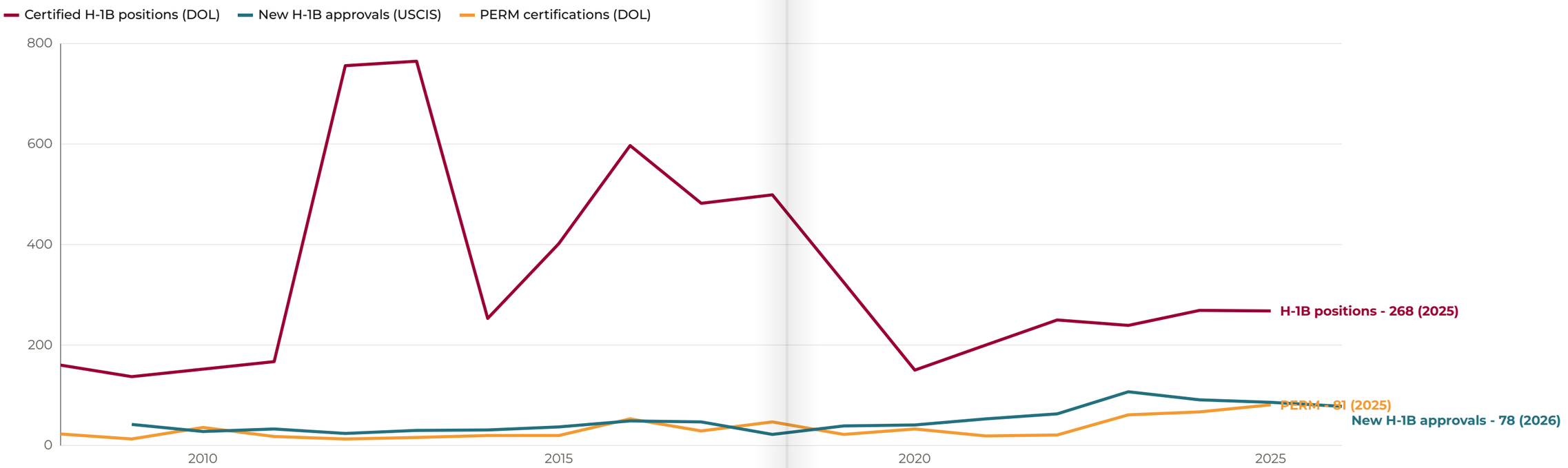
$265M
Federal R&D obligations, 2024
U.S. **$193B** · **46th** of 51 · +74% since 2015

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Montana ranks 50th of 51 on certified H-1B positions, by worksite, at 268 in 2025 against 914K for the U.S.

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does Montana Generate?



Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 268 H-1B positions at Montana worksites in FY2025, 50th of 51 among the states. A labor condition application comes before the petition and covers renewals and job changes as well as new hires, by the worksite's state, so it runs well above approvals. USCIS approved 78 new H-1B petitions in FY2026 and 95 continuing ones, counted by the employer's address.

DOL certified 81 PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 2.4% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

268

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **50th** of 51 · −33% since 2015

81

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

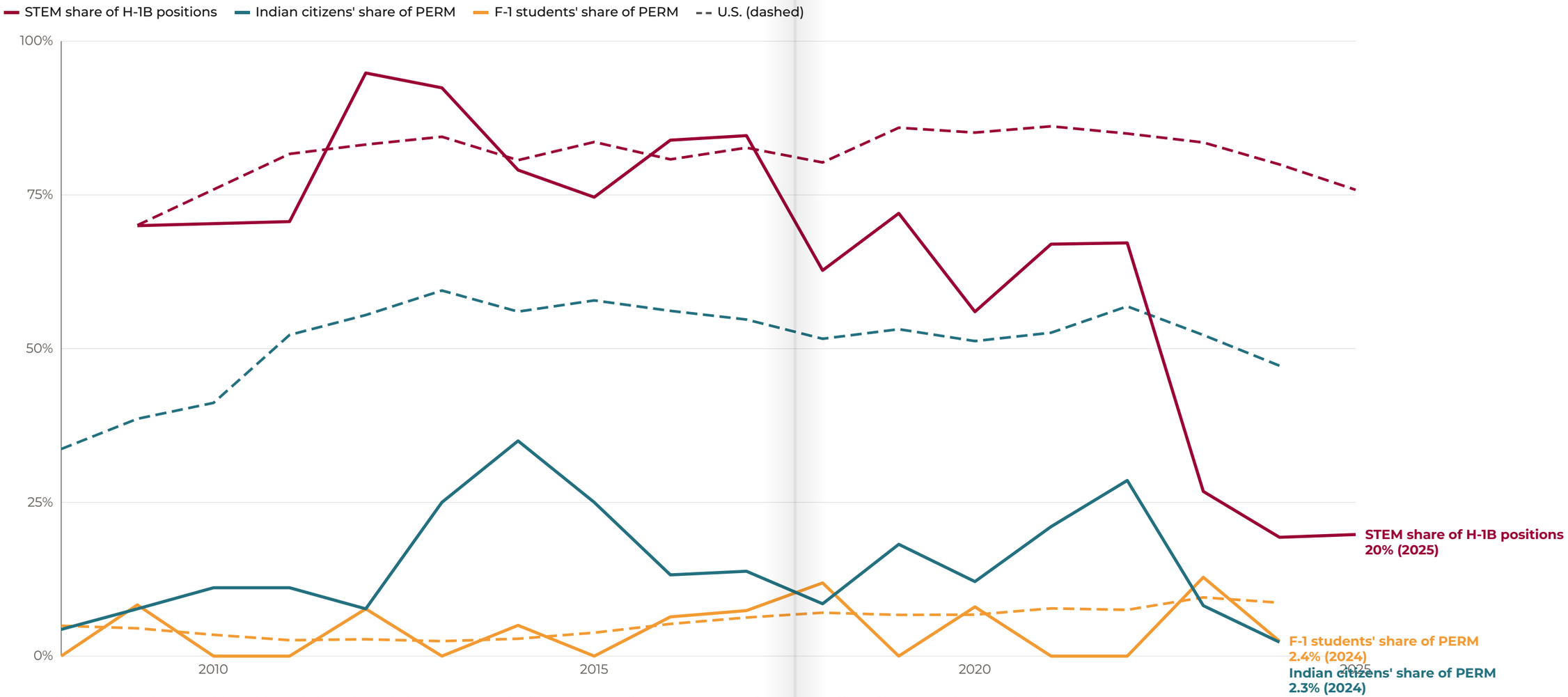
U.S. **138K** · **49th** of 51

2.4%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **50th** of 51 · +2.4 pp since 2015

Figure 19 Who Holds Montana's Skilled-Visa Jobs?



State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

20% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 2.3% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

20%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **48th** of 51 · −54.9 pp since 2015

2.3%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **50th** of 51 · −22.7 pp since 2015

$73.2K

Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

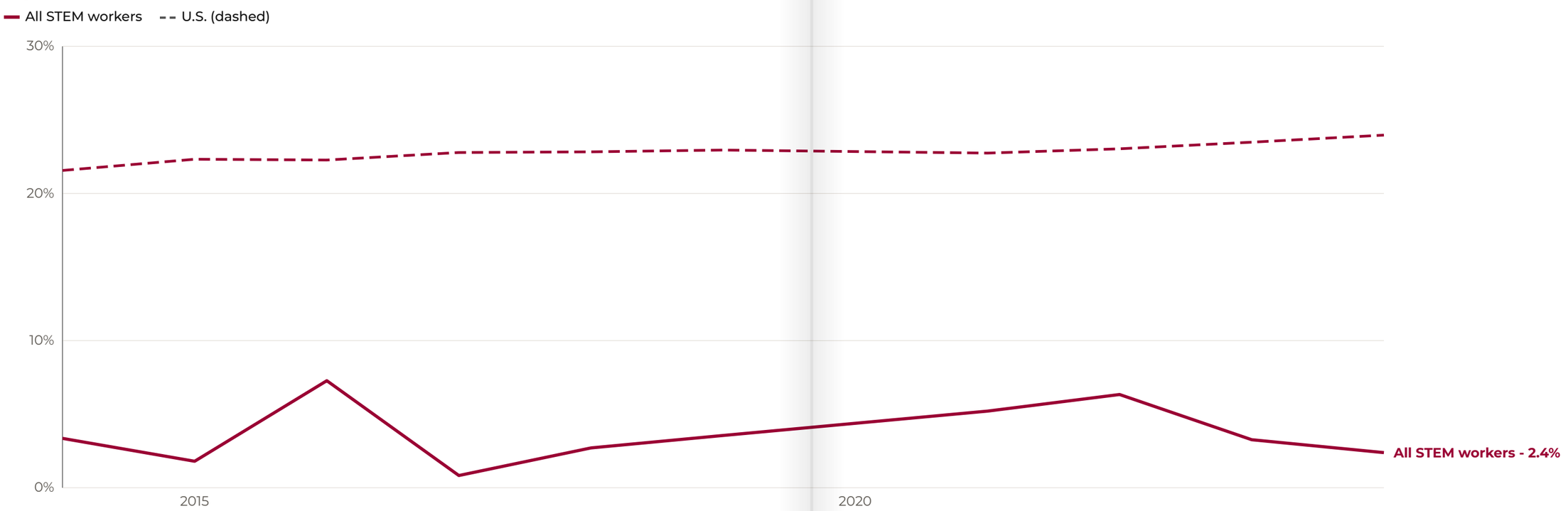
U.S. **$119K** · **48th** of 51 · +22% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

Montana ranks 51st of 51 on the foreign-born share of STEM workers, at 2.4% in 2024 against 24% for the U.S.

Figure 20 How Much of Montana's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resting on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey.

In 2024, 2.4% of the people working in STEM occupations in Montana were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 51st of 51).

2.4%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **51st** of 51 · +0.6 pp since 2015

1.2%

Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

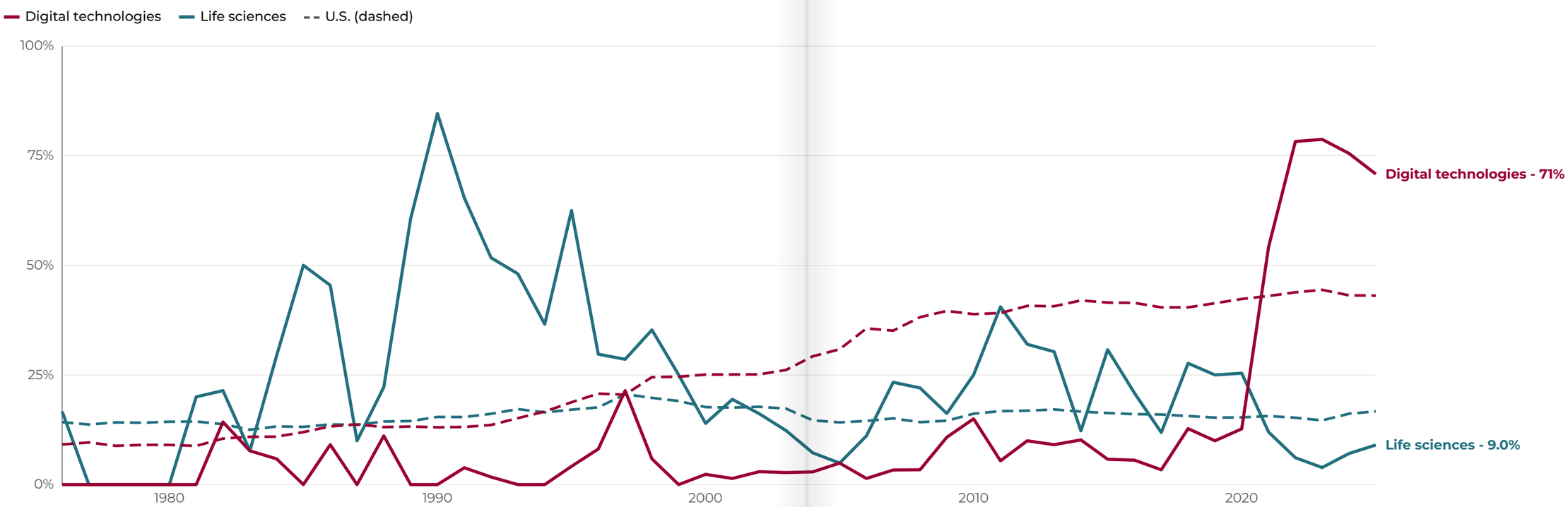
U.S. **11%** · **51st** of 51 · +0.1 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

Montana ranks 1st of 51 on the share of the state's patents in digital technologies, at 71% in 2025 against 43% for the U.S.

Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does Montana Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

Organizations and people in Montana were granted 233 U.S. patents in 2025, 0.2% of all patents with a U.S. owner (39th of 51).

71% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 9.0% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).

233

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **39th** of 51 · 4.47× since 2015

71%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **1st** of 51 · +65.0 pp since 2015

9.0%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

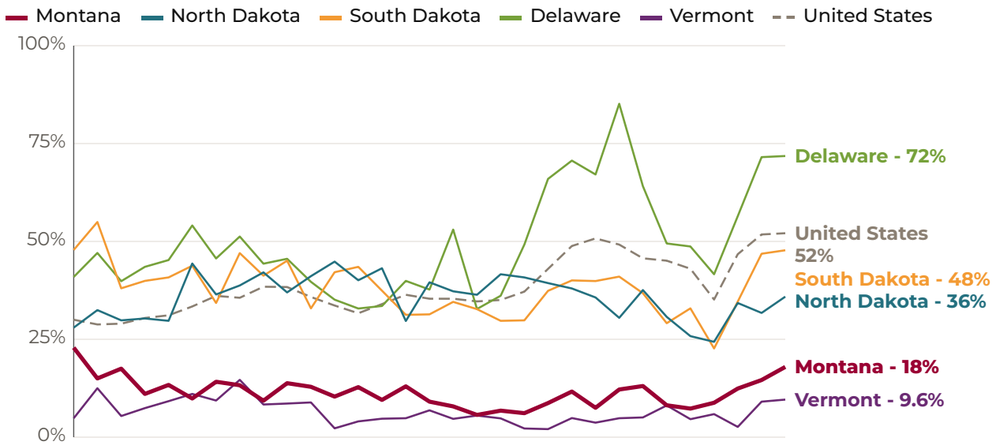
U.S. **17%** · **45th** of 51 · −21.8 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

The four states closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally (a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size), are North Dakota, South Dakota, Delaware, and Vermont. Montana ranks 4th of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Delaware is the most dependent at 72%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are Montana and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



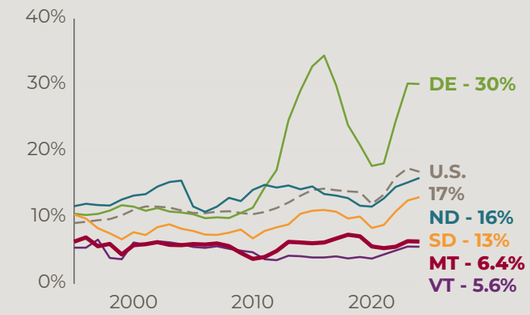
Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Table 4 How Does Montana Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	MT	ND	SD	DE	VT	U.S.
Students enrolled, 2024	**48.4K**	53.5K	54.2K	57.8K	38.3K	19.7M
Graduate share of students, 2024	**12%**	15%	17%	18%	15%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025	**32%**	21%	26%	22%	34%	24%
STEM share of master's, 2025	**22%**	18%	27%	38%	13%	23%
International STEM master's, 2025	**56**	122	277	1.03K	20	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025	**0.0%**	0.1%	0.2%	0.9%	0.0%	–
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025	**18%**	36%	48%	72%	9.6%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates, 2025	**12%**	57%	40%	52%	20%	43%
Int. share of grad students, 2024	**6.4%**	16%	13%	30%	5.6%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment, 2024	**1.1%**	2.7%	3.4%	3.5%	3.0%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024	**52%**	60%	58%	72%	70%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023	**$7.93K**	$9.87K	$9.25K	$11.8K	$17.5K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student, 2024	**$9.29K**	$11.9K	$9.61K	$8.9K	$5.33K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary, 2024	**$82K**	$82.6K	$79.3K	$123K	$94K	$106K
First-time students from in state, 2024	**58%**	50%	58%	58%	29%	–
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024	**+21**	+42	+22	+7	+55	–

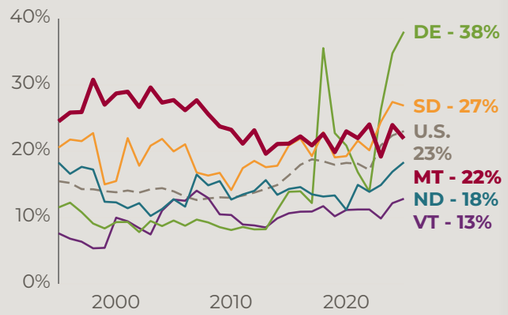
Latest year for each measure, given after its name. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



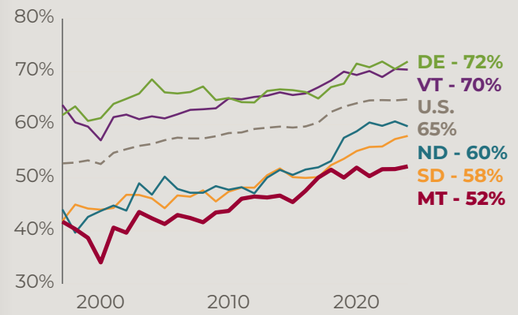
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



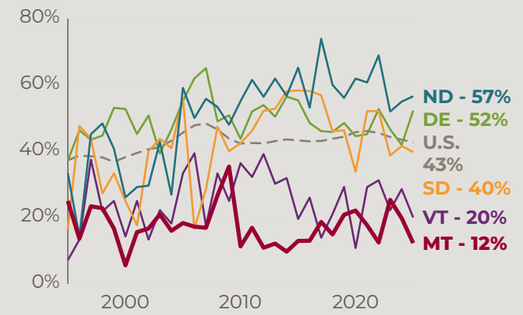
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM doctorates

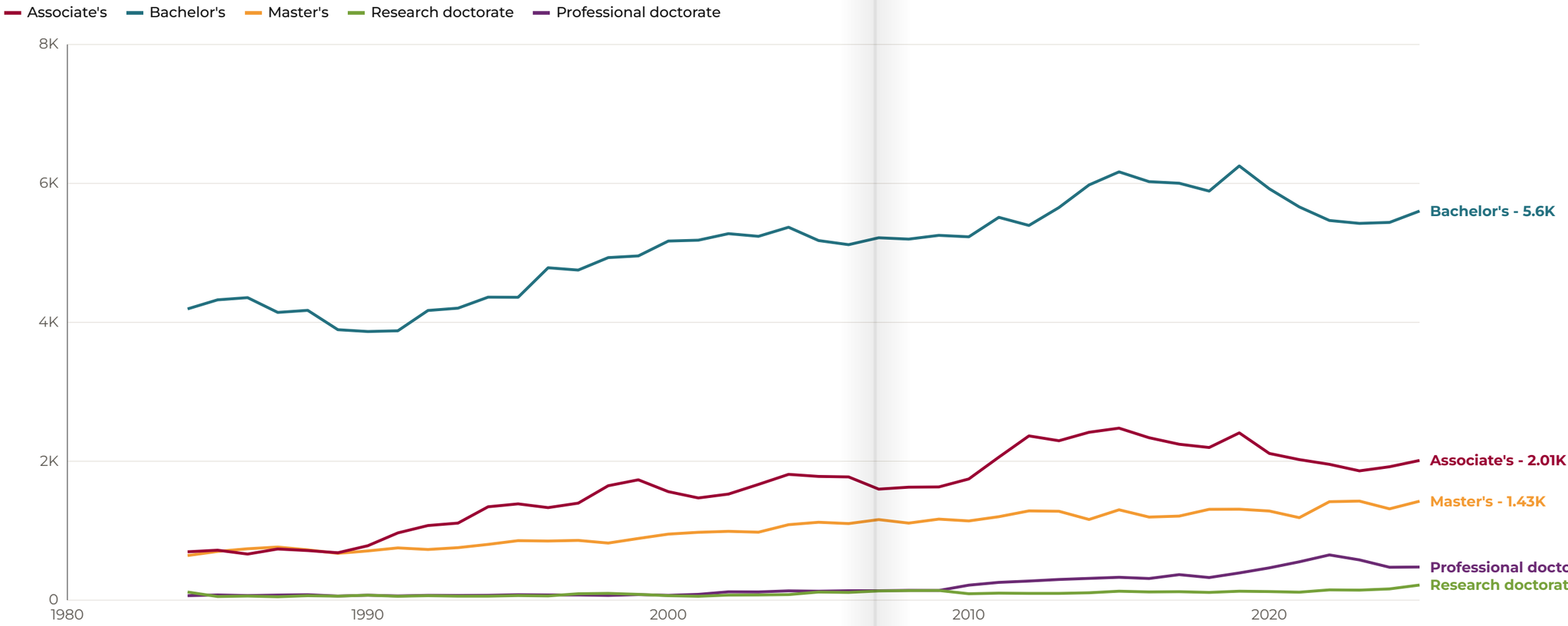


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does Montana Award?



Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, Montana's institutions awarded 2.01K associate's degrees, 5.6K bachelor's degrees, 1.43K master's degrees, 218 research doctorate degrees, 478 professional doctorate degrees.

Since 2015: associate's down 19%; bachelor's down 9%; master's up 10%; research doctorate up 69%; professional doctorate up 45%. The state awards 13.2 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

Figure 28 What Do Montana's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Montana's largest bachelor's fields are business (17%; U.S. 19%), health professions (9.9%; U.S. 13%), engineering (9.1%; U.S. 5.9%).

Relative to the nation, Montana's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in natural resources (4.62× the U.S. share), agriculture (2.33× the U.S. share), physical sciences (1.84× the U.S. share).

3.8%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **42nd** of 51 · +2.6 pp since 2015

10%

Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025

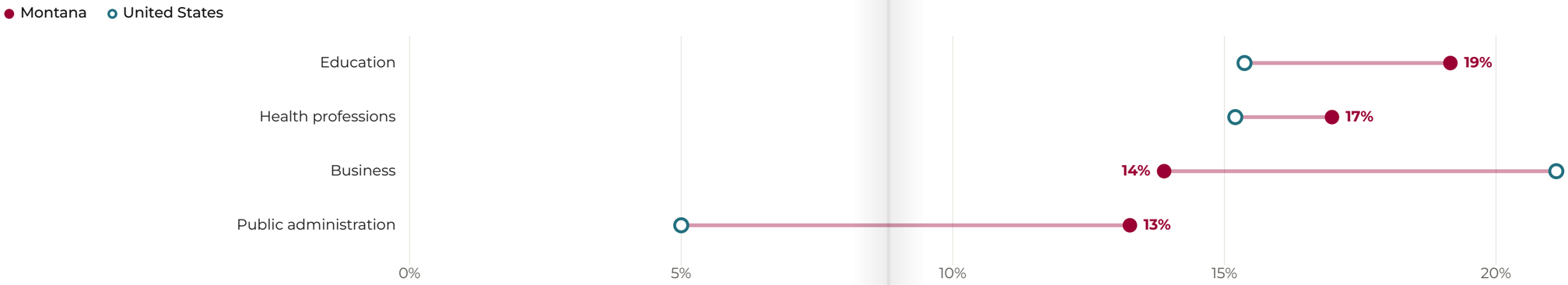
U.S. **6.8%** · **3rd** of 51 · −0.2 pp since 2015

17%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **41st** of 51 · +1.8 pp since 2015

Figure 29 What Do Montana's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Montana's largest master's fields are education (19%; U.S. 15%), health professions (17%; U.S. 15%), business (14%; U.S. 21%).

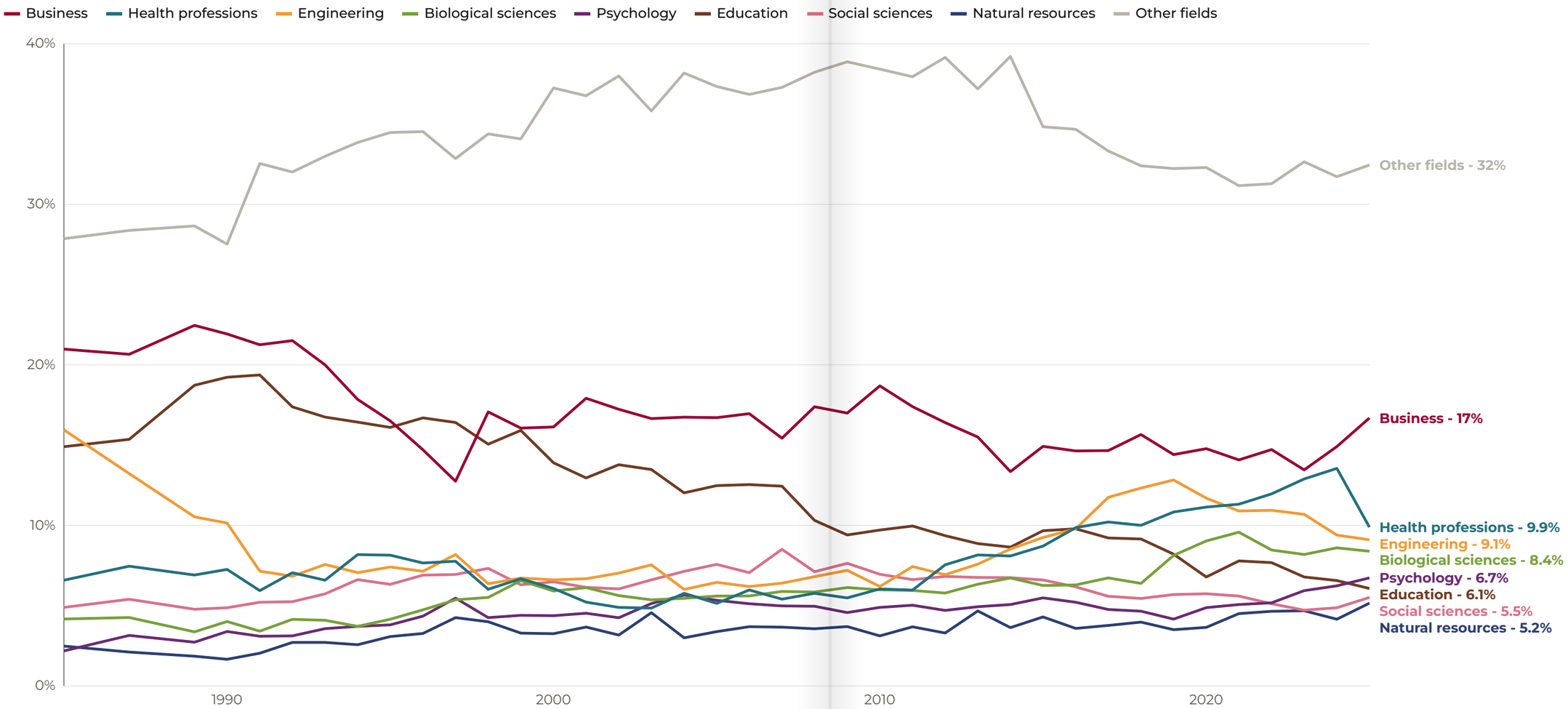
International students earn 5.5% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 22% of them.

22%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **23rd** of 51 · +0.7 pp since 2015

5.5%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **46th** of 51 · +2.0 pp since 2015

–
Int. share of CS master's, null

Figure 30 How Has Montana's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, biological sciences has gained the most ground, 2.1 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while education lost the most (3.6 points).

The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

SECTION 12 · FIELDS OF STUDY

Where Is Montana Most Specialized?

The location quotient divides a field's share of Montana's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the 10 fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

Highest location quotients. Natural resources (4.62, with 5.2% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 1.1% for the U.S.), agriculture (2.33, with 2.4% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 1.0% for the U.S.), and physical sciences (1.84, with 2.4% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 1.3% for the U.S.) had the highest quotients.

Table 5 Where Is Montana Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Natural resources	**4.62**	5.2%	1.1%	289
Agriculture	**2.33**	2.4%	1.0%	134
Physical sciences	**1.84**	2.4%	1.3%	133
Engineering	**1.55**	9.1%	5.9%	510
Education	**1.40**	6.1%	4.3%	340
Parks & recreation	**1.30**	3.4%	2.6%	191
Biological sciences	**1.28**	8.4%	6.6%	470
English	**1.20**	1.8%	1.5%	101
Visual & performing arts	**1.09**	5.0%	4.6%	280
Psychology	**0.97**	6.7%	6.9%	377

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

32%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **3rd** of 51

3.8%
Bachelor's in computer science, 2025
U.S. **6.9%** · **42nd** of 51

10%
Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025
U.S. **6.8%** · **3rd** of 51

17%
Bachelor's in business, 2025
U.S. **19%** · **41st** of 51

Engineering & eng. technology. The share was 10% in 2025, against 6.8% for the U.S., 3rd among the states, down 0.4 points from 11% in 2024 and down 0.2 points since 2015, when it was 11%.

Health professions. The share was 9.9% in 2025, against 12% for the U.S., 35th among the states, down 3.7 points from 14% in 2024 and up 1.2 points since 2015, when it was 8.7%.

Table 6 Montana at a Glance

Measure	2015	Previous	Latest	Change	U.S.	Rank
STEM share of bachelor's	26%	32% 2024	**32% 2025**	+5.8 pp	24%	3rd
Bachelor's in computer science	1.2%	3.8% 2024	**3.8% 2025**	+2.6 pp	6.9%	42nd
Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	11%	11% 2024	**10% 2025**	−0.2 pp	6.8%	3rd
Bachelor's in business	15%	15% 2024	**17% 2025**	+1.8 pp	19%	41st

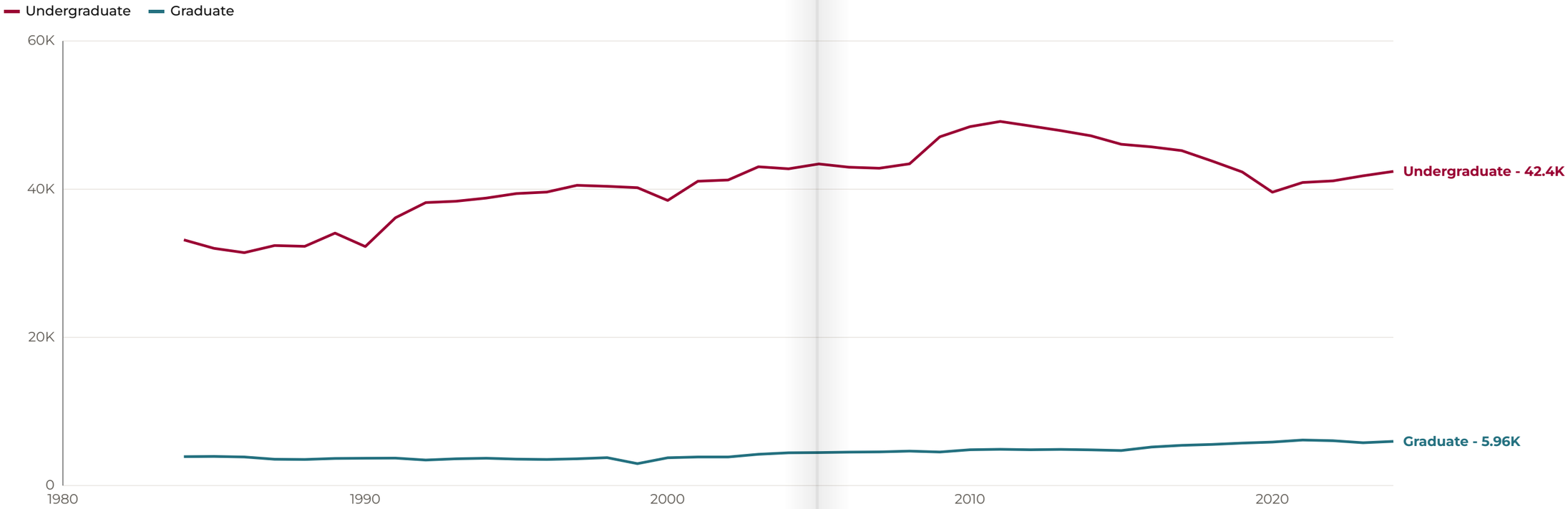
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 13

Students and Money

Montana ranks 48th of 51 on fall enrollment, at 48.4K in 2024 against 19.7M for the U.S.

Figure 31 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, Montana enrolled 42.4K undergraduates and 5.96K graduate students, 48.4K in all (48th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is down 8% since 2015 and graduate enrollment up 26% since 2015. Graduate students are 12% of all students (U.S. 17%).

48.4K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **48th** of 51 · −4.8% since 2015

12%

Graduate share of students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **42nd** of 51 · +3.0 pp since 2015

32%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **38th** of 51 · +4.8 pp since 2015

SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

Who Enrolls in Montana, and Where?

In fall 2024, White students were the largest group at Montana's degree-granting institutions, **73%** of enrollment against 45% nationally, down 3.3 points since 2015.

American Indian students were **6.5%** (U.S. 0.6%), down 0.9 points since 2015, and students of two or more races were **6.4%** (U.S. 4.2%), up 3.8 points since 2015.

Figure 32 Who Enrolls in Montana?

Montana United States

		Change since 2015
White	73% · U.S. 45%	−3.3 pts
American Indian	6.5% · U.S. 0.6%	−0.9 pts
Two or more	6.4% · U.S. 4.2%	+3.8 pts
Hispanic	5.7% · U.S. 21%	+2.2 pts
Asian / Pacific Islander	2.2% · U.S. 7.4%	+0.6 pts
International	1.7% · U.S. 5.3%	−1.7 pts
Black	1.0% · U.S. 12%	+0.1 pts

Share of fall 2024 headcount enrollment by race and ethnicity; students of unknown race are left out of the chart. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

73%
White students
U.S. **45%** · −3.3 pp since 2015

6.5%
American Indian students
U.S. **0.6%** · −0.9 pp since 2015

77%
At public 4-year institutions
+3.1 pp since 2015

16%
At public 2-year institutions
−0.4 pp since 2015

In fall 2024, public 4-year institutions enrolled **77%** of students, up 3.1 points from 74% in 2015. Public 2-year institutions enrolled **16%** of students, down 0.4 points from 17% in 2015.

Private nonprofit institutions enrolled **6.8%** of students, down 2.7 points from 9.6% in 2015, and for-profit institutions enrolled none of the state's students.

Public institutions together enrolled **93%** of students, against 73% nationally, 3rd among the states.

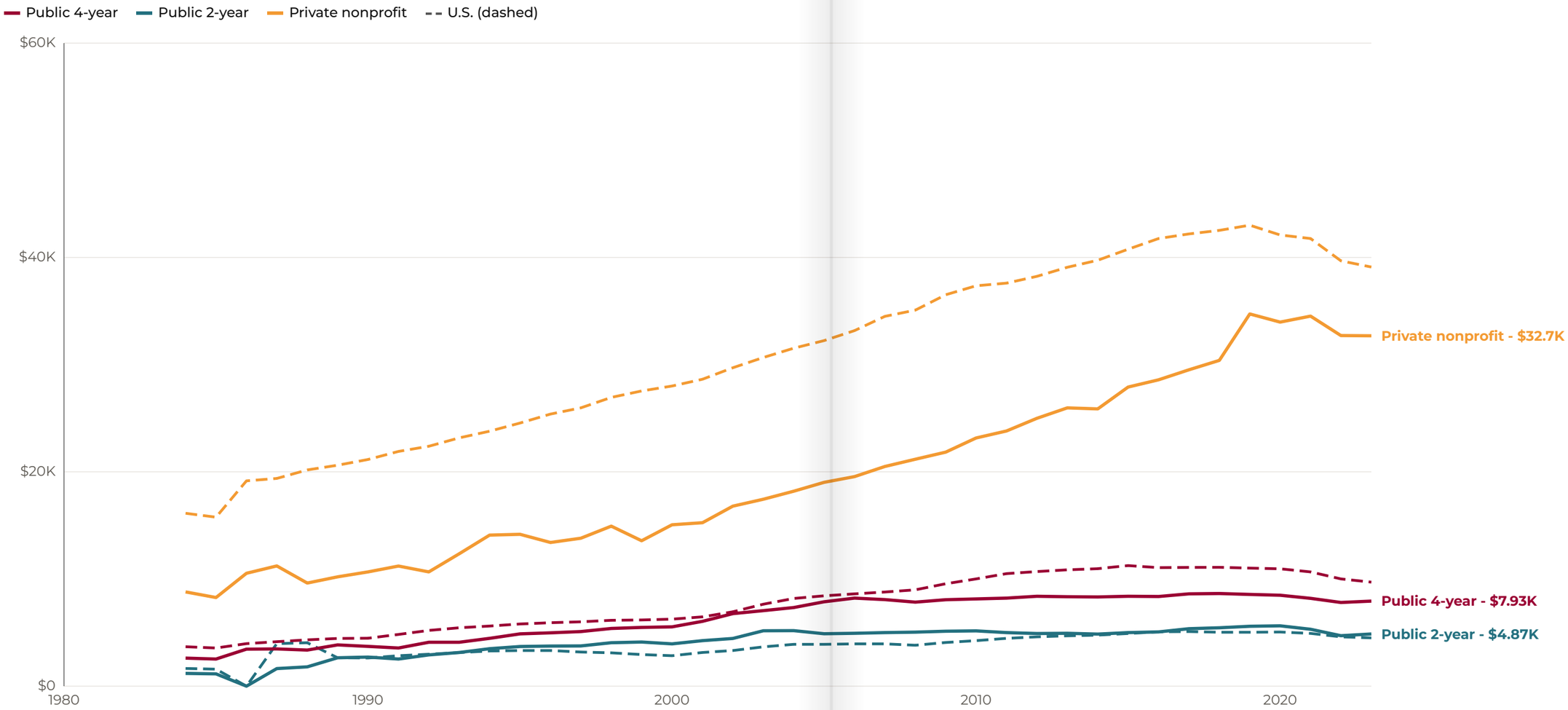
Figure 33 Where Do Students Enroll?



Share of fall headcount enrollment by sector, 2015, 2019, 2024. Sectors as IPEDS classifies them each year. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

13

Figure 34 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at Montana's public four-year institutions are $7.93K (2023, 2024 dollars), 18% below the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 44th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $9.29K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (36th of 51), and net tuition makes up 54% of net tuition plus state and local appropriations (U.S. 43%).

$7.93K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **44th** of 51 · −5.4% since 2015

$9.29K

Appropriations per student, 2024

U.S. **$11.4K** · **36th** of 51 · +11% since 2015

54%

Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **13th** of 51 · −1.1 pp since 2015

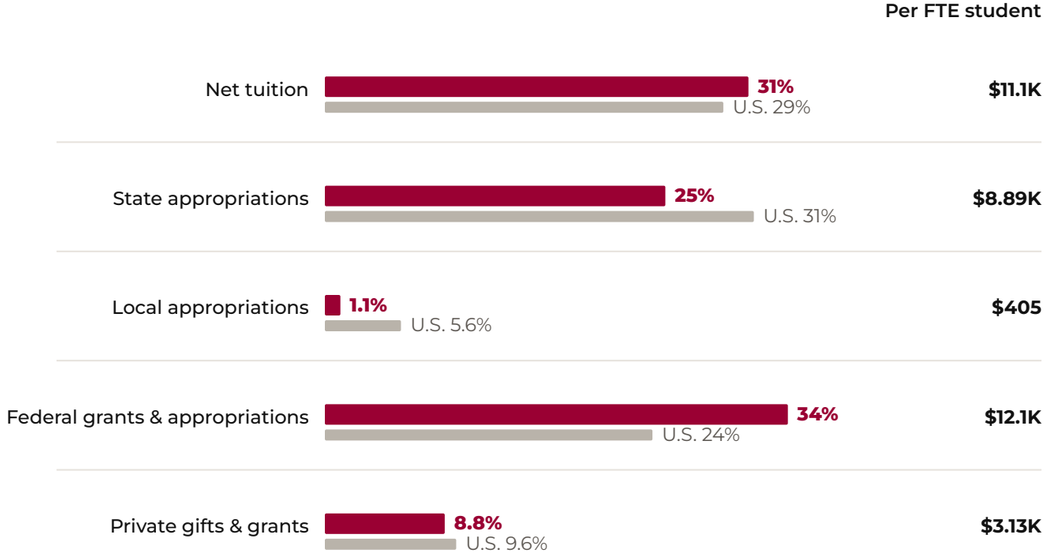
SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

How Are Montana's Public Institutions Funded, and What Do They Produce?

The bars give each source's share of the core revenue of Montana's public institutions, with the nation for comparison, and at right the dollars per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student it provides. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

Net tuition per FTE student. The figure was $11.1K in FY2024, against $8.96K for the U.S., up 3.2% from $10.7K in FY2023 and up 6.6% since FY2015, when it was $10.4K.

Figure 35 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



Share of core revenue per FTE student by source, public institutions, FY2024; dollars per FTE at right, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Shares are of all five sources; the tuition share elsewhere in this profile divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations only. Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

$7.93K
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023
U.S. **$9.71K** · **44th** of 51

$9.29K
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · **36th** of 51

54%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024
U.S. **43%** · **13th** of 51

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in Montana: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

In-state tuition, public 4-year. The figure was $7.93K in 2023, against $9.71K for the U.S., 44th among the states, up 1.6% from $7.81K in 2022 and down 5.4% since 2015, when it was $8.39K.

Table 7 Money and Results

Measure	Year	Montana	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$7.93K**	$9.71K	44th of 51	−5.4%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$9.29K**	$11.4K	36th of 51	+11%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations	2024	**54%**	43%	13th of 51	−1.1 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**52%**	65%	49th of 51	+6.7 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$82K**	$106K	43rd of 51	−4.3%

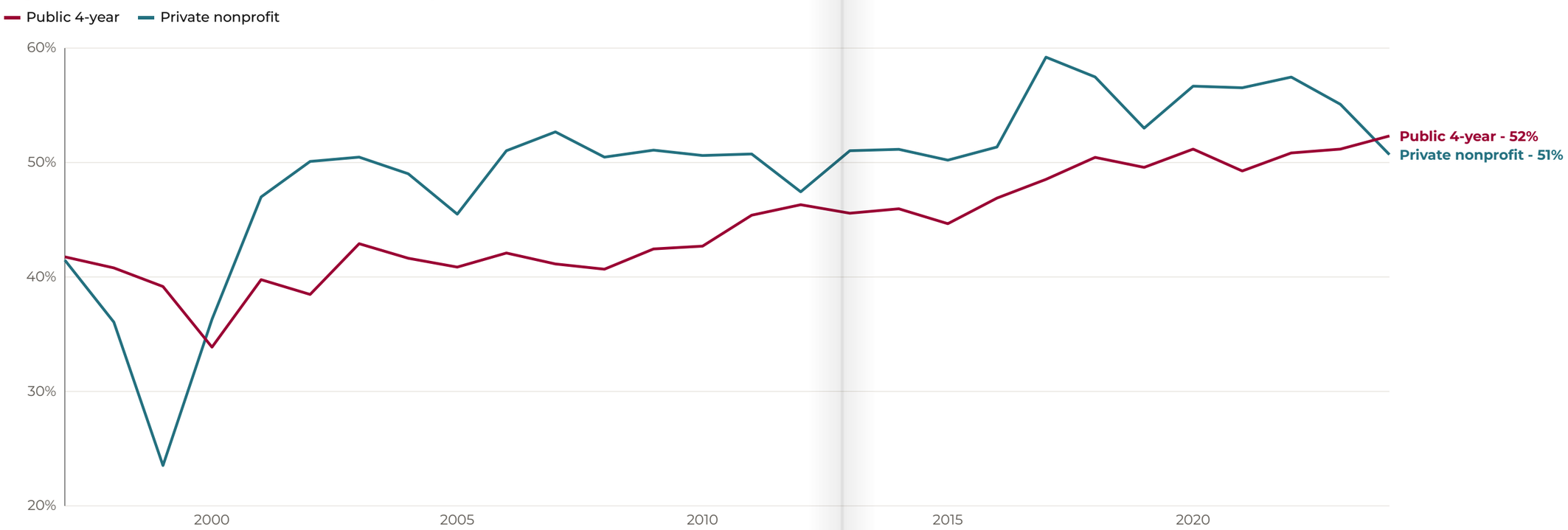
Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

Montana ranks 49th of 51 on the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions, at 52% in 2024 against 65% for the U.S.

Figure 36 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

52% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in Montana graduated within six years (2024), 12.6 points below the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 49th of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 52%, private nonprofit 51%. At two-year institutions, 37% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).

52%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **49th** of 51 · +6.7 pp since 2015

37%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **31st** of 50 · +14.4 pp since 2015

13.2
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **19th** of 51 · +0.2 since 2015

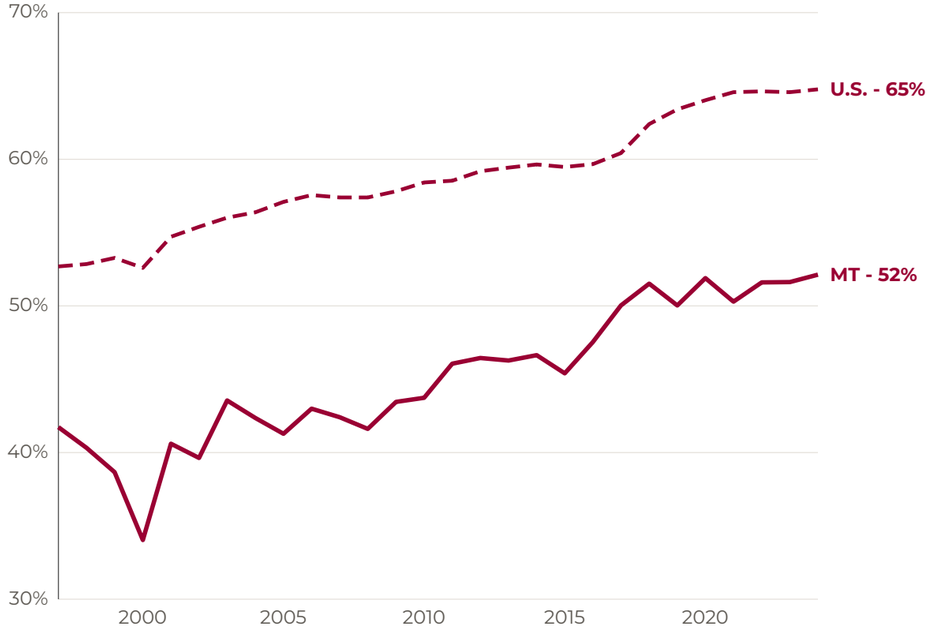
SECTION 14 · STUDENT OUTCOMES

How Many of Montana's Students Graduate?

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at Montana's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The rate leaves out students who start part-time (32% of the state's students attend part-time, against 39% nationally) and students who transfer and finish elsewhere. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Six-year graduation rate. The rate was 52% in 2024, against 65% for the U.S., up 0.5 points from 52% in 2023 and up 6.7 points since 2015, when it was 45%.

Figure 37 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

52%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **49th** of 51

37%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **31st** of 50

13.2
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **19th** of 51

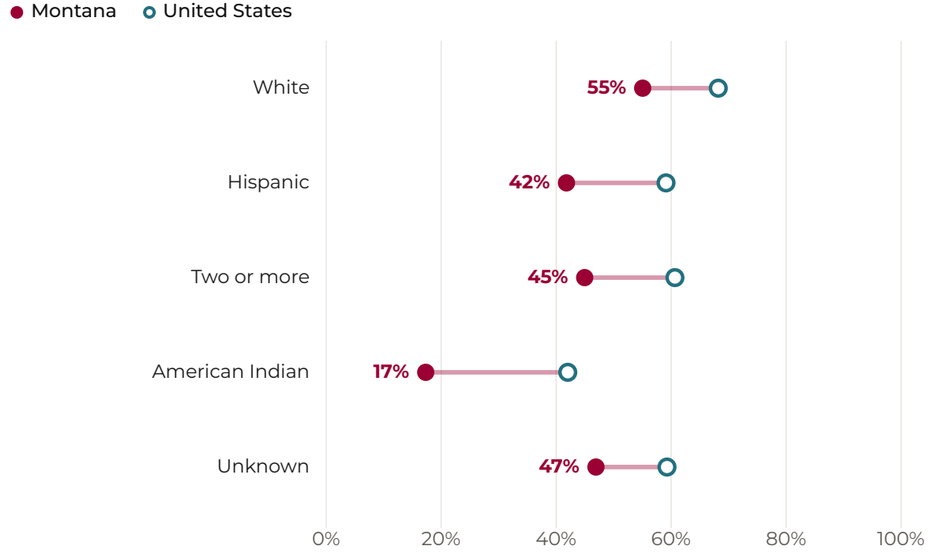
Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at Montana's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

White. The six-year rate was 55% in 2024, against 68% for the U.S.

Hispanic. The six-year rate was 42% in 2024, against 59% for the U.S.

Two or more. The six-year rate was 45% in 2024, against 61% for the U.S.

Figure 38 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



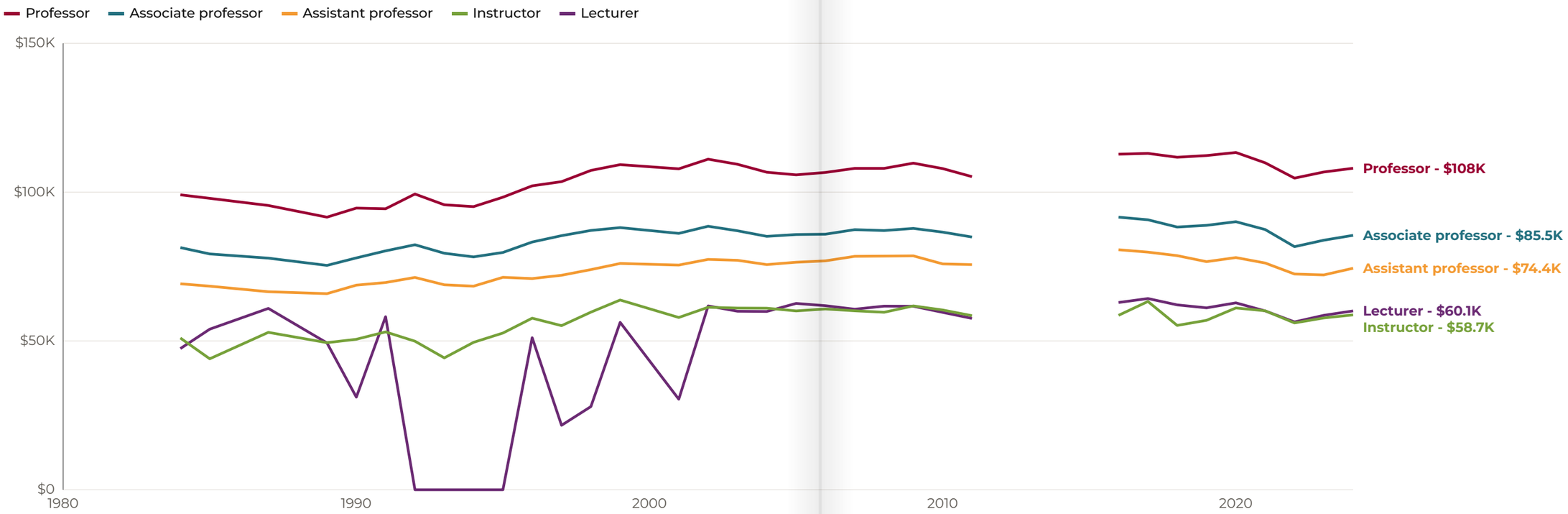
Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 15

Faculty

Montana ranks 43rd of 51 on the average full-time faculty salary, at $82K in 2024 against $106K for the U.S.

Figure 39 What Do Montana's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at Montana's institutions earned an average of $82K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 22% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 43rd of 51. By rank (2024): professors $108K, associate professors $85.5K, assistant professors $74.4K, instructors $58.7K, lecturers $60.1K.

Montana's institutions had 2K full-time instructional staff in 2024, down 6% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 4% since 2016.

$82K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **43rd** of 51 · −4.3% since 2016

SECTION 15 · FACULTY

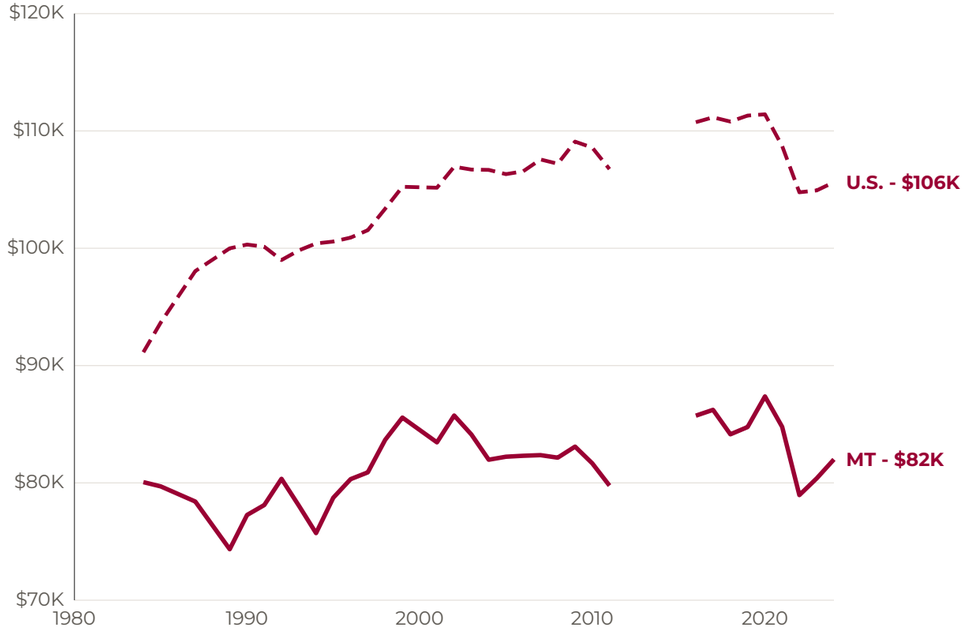
What Do Montana's Faculty Earn, and How Many Hold Tenure?

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at Montana's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Average salary. The figure was $82K in 2024, against $106K for the U.S., 43rd among the states, up 2.0% from $80.4K in 2023 and down 4.3% since 2016, when it was $85.7K.

Full-time instructional staff. The number was 2K in 2024, up 2.8% from 1.95K in 2023 and down 6.4% since 2015, when it was 2.14K.

Figure 40 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

$82K
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · **43rd** of 51

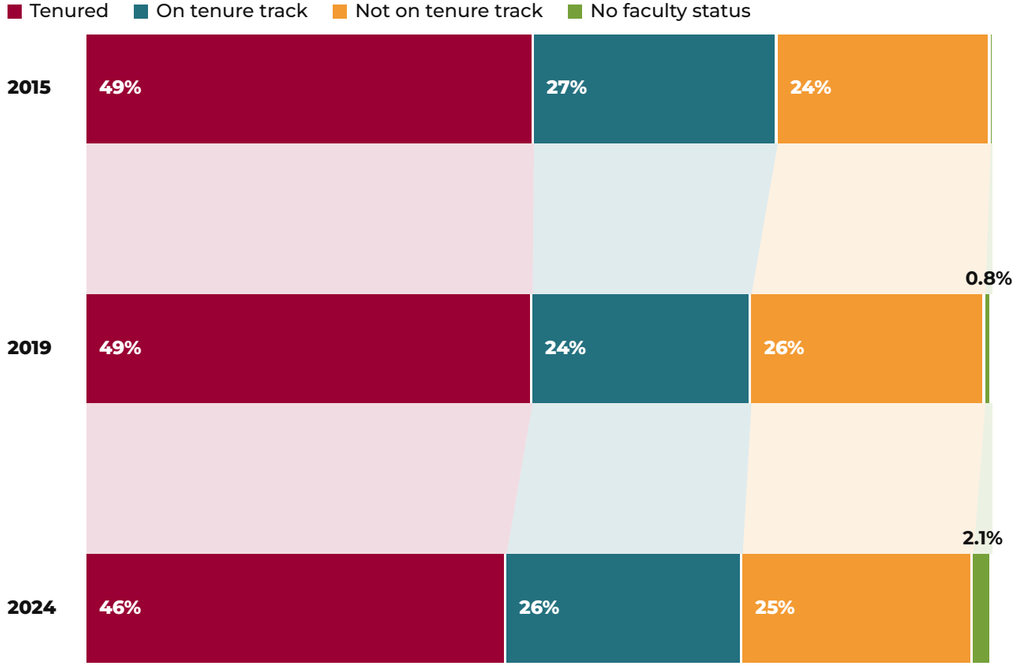
2K
Full-time instructional staff, 2024

46%
Tenured, 2024

The bars divide Montana's full-time instructional staff by tenure status in 2015, 2019 and 2024: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff. The share was 46% in 2024, down 1.8 points from 48% in 2023 and down 3.0 points since 2015, when it was 49%.

Figure 41 Tenure Status



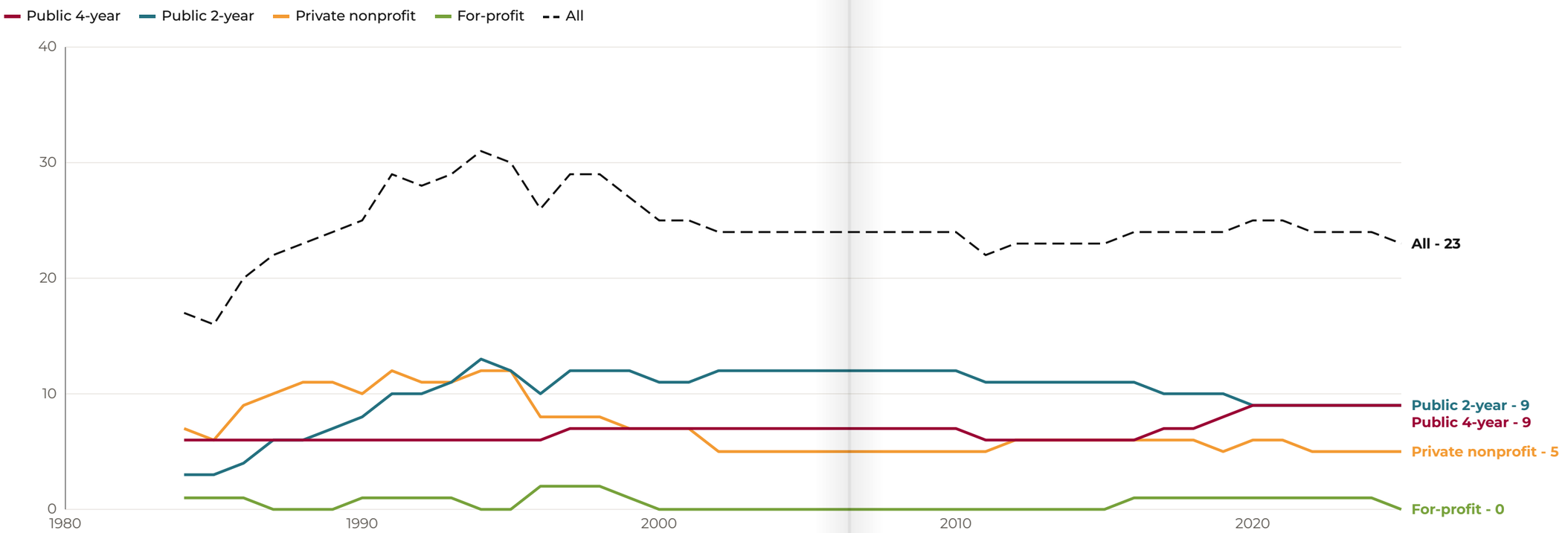
Full-time instructional staff by tenure status, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 16

Institutions

Montana ranks 3rd of 51 on the share of enrollment at public institutions, at 93% in 2024 against 73% for the U.S.

Figure 42 How Many Institutions Does Montana Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Montana has 23 degree-granting institutions:9 public 4-year, 9 public 2-year, 5 private nonprofit, 0 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is roughly flat since 2015. 93% of students attend public institutions and 0.0% attend for-profit ones.

93%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **3rd** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

0.0%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **46th** of 51 · 0.0 pp since 2015

15%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **48th** of 51 · +8.1 pp since 2015

SECTION 16 · INSTITUTIONS

Which Institutions Lead in Montana?

The table ranks institutions in Montana by the STEM master's degrees and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025, the two counted together. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

Largest. Montana State University (43 international STEM master's degrees and 7 doctorates), Montana Technological University (6 international STEM master's degrees and 4 doctorates), and The University of Montana (7 international STEM master's degrees and 2 doctorates) awarded the most.

Table 8 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	STEM total	STEM master's	Int. share	STEM doctorates	Int. share
Montana State University Bozeman · Public 4-year	**50**	43	20%	7	9.5%
Montana Technological University Butte · Public 4-year	**10**	6	18%	4	67%
The University of Montana Missoula · Public 4-year	**9**	7	11%	2	7.7%

Ranked by the total (shaded) of international STEM master's degrees and research doctorates. Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

23
Degree-granting institutions, 2025

93%
Students at public institutions, 2024
U.S. **73%** · **3rd** of 51

0.0%
Students at for-profit institutions, 2024
U.S. **5.5%** · **46th** of 51

15%
Students fully online, 2024
U.S. **27%** · **48th** of 51

The table lists Montana's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

Largest. The three largest were Montana State University (17.1K students), The University of Montana (10.8K students), and Montana State University Billings (4.13K students).

Degree-granting institutions. The state had 23 in 2025, and 23 of them reported the enrollment and degree data in these tables.

Table 9 What Are Montana's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
Montana State University	**17.1K**	12%	1.09K	57%	82%
The University of Montana	**10.8K**	3.5%	397	49%	96%
Montana State University Billings	**4.13K**	1.2%	23	34%	–
Flathead Valley Community College	**2.23K**	–	–	–	–
Montana Technological University	**1.7K**	15%	149	58%	91%
Helena College University of Montana	**1.55K**	–	–	–	–
Great Falls College Montana State University	**1.5K**	–	–	–	–
The University of Montana-Western	**1.36K**	–	29	54%	100%
Carroll College	**1.16K**	–	62	69%	71%
Rocky Mountain College	**1.03K**	0.6%	29	48%	70%

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

Tuition, appropriations, revenue and faculty salaries are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Research funding (HERD, Federal Funds, USAspending), wages and the NAFSA economic contribution are nominal dollars, and are labeled so. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions; the tuition share divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts. Year-to-year comparisons use one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November).

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally: a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size.

Sources

IPEDS (National Center for Education Statistics) is the backbone: Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. The profile also draws on NAEP, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates, Survey of Earned Doctorates, HERD and Federal Funds surveys, USAspending.gov, DHS SEVIS by the Numbers and ICE SEVIS releases, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification and BLS wage data, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, USPTO PatentsView, and other federal sources; every figure names its source, and the Sources page lists them in full. Generated November 2026.

NOTES

How the Numbers Are Counted

Ranks

Ranks are among the 50 states and the District of Columbia (1 = highest value, whether or not a high value is good). Where fewer than 51 report, the count is given ("23rd of 33").

Sectors

Sectors are as IPEDS classifies institutions each year. IPEDS moves a whole institution to "public, 4-year or above" once it awards any bachelor's degree, so community colleges that began offering applied bachelor's degrees carry all of their students into the public 4-year sector. Sector series (enrollment shares, public 4-year tuition, graduation rates by sector) reflect these moves.

Research doctorates

Two counts appear. IPEDS counts degrees institutions report as "doctor's degree, research/scholarship", which includes some practice-oriented degrees such as many Ed.D.s; the NSF Survey of Earned Doctorates counts research doctorate recipients and is smaller. Each figure names which it uses. "STEM master's per STEM research doctorate" divides IPEDS STEM master's degrees by IPEDS STEM research doctorates.

Engineering

"Engineering" alone is CIP 14. Where engineering technology (CIP 15) is added, the label says "engineering & eng. technology".

Graduation rates

IPEDS graduation rates follow first-time, full-time students and count only those who finish at the institution where they started, so they leave out part-time starters and students who transfer and finish elsewhere.

International students in SEVIS

SEVIS counts active F-1 and M-1 records, which include graduates on Optional Practical Training (up to 36 months for STEM graduates, 12 for others), so STEM shares run high. STEM follows the DHS STEM Designated Degree Program List, which is broader than the eight CIP families above, and DHS draws its STEM pages on a different basis from its all-student pages, so a country's STEM count can exceed its all-level count.

Visas and green cards

DOL labor condition applications (H-1B positions) are counted by worksite and include renewals and job changes; USCIS approvals are counted by the employer's address and split into new and continuing. PERM certifications are the employer's step toward a green card.

Patents

Patents are counted by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live; a company headquartered in another state takes its patents there.

Years

Each measure uses its latest year, so years differ across a page; every figure, table and statement gives its year, and lines that stop early are labeled with their last year.

Montana – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	287	**279**[2024]	−8.4 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#10	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	39%	**32%**[2024]	−6.8 pp ▼	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#10	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	241	**238**[2024]	−2.8 ▼	237	−2.5 ▼	#20	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	41%	**40%**[2024]	−0.5 pp ▼	39%	0.0 pp	#21	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	270	**261**[2024]	−9.4 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#11	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	37%	**31%**[2024]	−5.7 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#13	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	225	**217**[2024]	−7.5 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#12	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**161**[2015]	–	153	–	#6	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$14.5K	**$15.6K**[2021]	+7.7% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#28	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	86%	**86%**[2022]	0.0 pp	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#25	[3]
Public high school graduates	9.38K	**9.77K**[2024]	+4.2% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#44	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$66.3K	**$58.9K**[2022]	−11% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#42	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	14.0	**13.7**[2022]	−0.3 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#31	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	145K	**147K**[2024]	+1.3% ▲	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#43	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	44%	**19%**[2023]	−24.9 pp ▼	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#51	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	2.2%	**2.4%**[2022]	+0.2 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#49	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	0.0%	**0.0%**[2020]	0.0 pp	6.8%	+1.4 pp ▲	#44	[3]
High schools offering calculus	66%[2016]	**44%**[2024]	−22.3 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#31	[14]
High schools offering physics	69%[2016]	**51%**[2024]	−18.8 pp ▼	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#41	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	81%[2016]	**70%**[2024]	−11.1 pp ▼	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#47	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	94%[2016]	**86%**[2024]	−8.2 pp ▼	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#40	[14]
High schools offering computer science	56%[2021]	**50%**[2024]	−5.9 pp ▼	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#35	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	43%[2016]	**36%**[2024]	−7.4 pp ▼	56%	0.0 pp	#44	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	2.3%[2021]	**2.8%**[2024]	+0.4 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#51	[14]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	56%[2016]	**63%[2024]**	+7.0 pp ▲	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#43	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	10.6[2016]	**12.6[2024]**	+2.0 ▲	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#38	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	4.2[2016]	**2.5[2024]**	−1.7 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#30	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	5.0[2016]	**4.5[2024]**	−0.5 ▼	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#40	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	24.3[2016]	**19.5[2024]**	−4.8 ▼	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#25	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	3.5[2016]	**3.6[2024]**	+0.1 ▲	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#33	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	35%	**27%[2025]**	−8.2 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#47	[15]
Fall enrollment	50.8K	**48.4K[2024]**	−4.8% ▼	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#48	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	90%	**93%[2024]**	+2.7 pp ▲	73%	0.0 pp	#3	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	0.0%	**0.0%[2024]**	0.0 pp	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#46	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	28%	**32%[2024]**	+4.8 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#38	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	9.3%	**12%[2024]**	+3.0 pp ▲	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#42	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	6.8%	**15%[2024]**	+8.1 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#48	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	128	**151[2025]**	+18% ▲	59K	+7.3% ▲	#45	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	96	**124[2025]**	+29% ▲	44.4K	+14% ▲	#45	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	0.2%	**0.3%[2025]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#45	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	8	**27[2025]**	–	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#44	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	6	**5[2025]**	–	5.07K	+33% ▲	#47	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	3.2	**2.9[2025]**	−0.3 ▼	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#45	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	26%	**32%[2025]**	+5.8 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	1.2%	**3.8%[2025]**	+2.6 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#42	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	11%	**10%[2025]**	−0.2 pp ▼	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.1%	**0.9%[2025]**	−0.2 pp ▼	1.2%	0.0 pp	#26	[4]

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MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	6.3%	**8.4%**[2025]	+2.1 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#6	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	2.1%	**2.4%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#1	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	8.7%	**9.9%**[2025]	+1.2 pp ▲	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#35	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	15%	**17%**[2025]	+1.8 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#41	[4]
STEM share of master's	21%	**22%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#23	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	1.6%	**1.5%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#48	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	4.8%	**5.2%**[2025]	+0.4 pp ▲	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#30	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	2.2%	**2.9%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#1	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	1.2%	**2.3%**[2025]	+1.2 pp ▲	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#30	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	3.2%	**2.6%**[2025]	−0.6 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#3	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	14%	**17%**[2025]	+3.4 pp ▲	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#14	[4]
Share of master's in business	8.7%	**14%**[2025]	+5.2 pp ▲	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#49	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	66%	**49%**[2025]	−17.3 pp ▼	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#13	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	2.3%	**1.4%**[2025]	−0.9 pp ▼	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#45	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	5.4%	**12%**[2025]	+7.0 pp ▲	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#29	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	4.7%	**0.9%**[2025]	−3.7 pp ▼	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#44	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	19%	**14%**[2025]	−4.8 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#15	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	21%	**11%**[2025]	−9.9 pp ▼	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#10	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	0.8%	**29%**[2025]	+28.1 pp ▲	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#5	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	0.0%	**0.0%**[2025]	0.0 pp	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#48	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	13.1	**13.2**[2025]	+0.2 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#19	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	1.3%[2016]	**0.9%**[2024]	−0.4 pp ▼	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#48	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	24	**56**[2025]	–	117K	2.18× ▲	#46	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	0.0%	**0.0%**[2025]	0.0 pp	–	–	#46	[4]

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MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	3.2%	**1.1%**[2024]	−2.1 pp ▼	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#49	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	6.1%	**6.4%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#45	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	2.7%	**1.1%**[2025]	−1.5 pp ▼	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#51	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	4.7%	**1.2%**[2025]	−3.5 pp ▼	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#51	[4]
International share of all master's	3.5%	**5.5%**[2025]	+2.0 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#46	[4]
International share of STEM master's	8.7%	**18%**[2025]	+9.2 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#45	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	13%	**20%**[2025]	+7.4 pp ▲	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#45	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	10%[2016]	**26%**[2025]	+16.2 pp ▲	55%	+1.8 pp ▲	#32	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	7.7%[2020]	**18%**[2025]	+10.5 pp ▲	23%	+7.6 pp ▲	#25	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	7.3%	**27%**[2025]	+19.7 pp ▲	33%	+3.6 pp ▲	#26	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	10%	**15%**[2025]	+4.6 pp ▲	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#45	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	13%	**12%**[2025]	−0.7 pp ▼	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#50	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	14%[2019]	**10%**[2025]	−4.3 pp ▼	23%	−1.3 pp ▼	#41	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	1.68K	**849**[2026]	−50% ▼	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#50	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.1%	**0.1%**[2026]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#50	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	3.4%	**6.6%**[2026]	+3.1 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#46	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	14%	**2.9%**[2026]	−10.8 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#48	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	38%	**28%**[2026]	−10.2 pp ▼	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#39	[20]
Countries of citizenship represented	103	**89**[2026]	−14% ▼	219	−2.7% ▼	#50	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	843	**478**[2026]	−43% ▼	749K	+61% ▲	#50	[20]
Active STEM master's students	77	**150**[2026]	+95% ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#49	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	93	**209**[2026]	2.25× ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#49	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	30%	**28%**[2026]	−1.9 pp ▼	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#48	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	683[2017]	**686**[2024]	+0.4% ▲	–	–	#45	[1]

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MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Economic contribution of international students, nominal dollars	$52.5M[2018]	**$31.1M[2024]**	−41% ▼	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#49	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	490[2018]	**207[2024]**	−58% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#49	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.2%	**0.2%[2024]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#46	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.1%[2024]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#49	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.6%[2024]**	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#33	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	2.48K	**3.13K[2025]**	+26% ▲	275K	−14% ▼	#29	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	1.42K	**1.55K[2016]**	+8.8% ▲	620K	+0.4% ▲	#47	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	152	**179[2016]**	+18% ▲	241K	+2.3% ▲	#49	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	11%	**12%[2016]**	+0.9 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#51	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	18%	**23%[2016]**	+5.2 pp ▲	57%	0.0 pp	#51	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	88	**81[2016]**	−8.0% ▼	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#45	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	22%	**36%[2016]**	+14.2 pp ▲	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#48	[9]
University R&D spending, nominal dollars	$182M	**$425M[2024]**	2.34× ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#41	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	0.3%	**0.4%[2024]**	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#41	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	59%	**62%[2024]**	+2.7 pp ▲	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#9	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	1.8%	**0.5%[2024]**	−1.3 pp ▼	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#51	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	6.1%	**6.8%[2024]**	+0.7 pp ▲	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#19	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science, nominal dollars	$2.07M	**$10.7M[2024]**	5.15× ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#44	[6]
University R&D in engineering, nominal dollars	$24M	**$88.8M[2024]**	3.70× ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#37	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	2.36K	**2.24K[2024]**	−5.0% ▼	1.09M	+20% ▲	#49	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$152M	**$265M[2024]**	+74% ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#46	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state, nominal dollars	$77.2M	**$177M[2024]**	2.29× ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#40	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$19.1M	**$84.4M[2024]**	4.42× ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#40	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$53.9M	**$82M[2024]**	+52% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#41	[8]

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MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state, nominal dollars	$61.6M	**$79.5M[2025]**	+29% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#47	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state, nominal dollars	$7.81M	**$13.8M[2026]**	+6.0 ▲	$59.3B	+22,105.9 ▲	#47	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$47.7K[2020]	**$48.8K[2022]**	+2.3% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#24	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$50.1K[2025]**	–	$47.5K	–	#17	[15]
Median debt of completers, nominal dollars	$23K	**$19.5K[2024]**	−15% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#18	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$63.5K[2025]**	–	$68.2K	–	#38	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$43.5K[2025]**	–	$51.9K	–	#50	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$59.9K[2025]**	–	$68.1K	–	#47	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$72.2K[2025]**	–	$91.6K	–	#42	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	45%	**52%[2024]**	+6.7 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#49	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	23%	**37%[2024]**	+14.4 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#31	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$8.39K	**$7.93K[2023]**	−5.4% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#44	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$8.34K	**$9.29K[2024]**	+11% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#36	[4]
Net tuition share of tuition plus state and local appropriations, public institutions	55%	**54%[2024]**	−1.1 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#13	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$85.7K[2016]	**$82K[2024]**	−4.3% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#43	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	48%	**52%[2016]**	+3.5 pp ▲	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#8	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	42%	**48%[2016]**	+6.1 pp ▲	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#20	[21]
OPT retention, master's graduates	59%	**64%[2016]**	+5.2 pp ▲	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#2	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	40%	**50%[2016]**	+10.0 pp ▲	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#5	[21]
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.95	**0.82[2016]**	−0.1 ▼	1.00	0.0	#28	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	12	**23[2016]**	–	41.2K	+51% ▲	#47	[21]

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MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	62%[2016]	**63%[2019]**	+1.1 pp ▲	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#20	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**55%[2016]**	–	65%	–	#22	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**52%[2010]**	–	64%	–	#22	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	52%[2016]	**55%[2019]**	+2.6 pp ▲	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#22	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**62%[2016]**	–	66%	–	#19	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**33%[2016]**	–	49%	–	#34	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$41.4K[2016]	**$43.2K[2019]**	+4.4% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#31	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$60.7K[2016]**	–	$67.3K	–	#32	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$54K[2016]	**$52.3K[2019]**	−3.1% ▼	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#29	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	+12.5	**+1.8[2025]**	−10.7 ▼	–	–	#22	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	+1.31K	**+441[2025]**	−869.0 ▼	–	–	#20	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	4.4%	**3.3%[2025]**	−1.0 pp ▼	–	–	#16	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	3.1%	**3.1%[2025]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#15	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	1.03K	**714[2025]**	−31% ▼	–	–	#49	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	65%[2016]	**58%[2024]**	−6.8 pp ▼	–	–	#42	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+20[2016]	**+21[2024]**	+0.5 ▲	–	–	#13	[4]
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	22%[2016]	**28%[2022]**	+6.1 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#17	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	402	**268[2025]**	−33% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#50	[17]
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	0.0%	**0.0%[2025]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#50	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	75%	**20%[2025]**	−54.9 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#48	[17]
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$60K	**$73.2K[2025]**	+22% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#48	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	33%	**8.2%[2025]**	−24.6 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#42	[17]

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MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Green-card labor certifications	20	**81**[2025]	–	138K	+75% ▲	#49	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	25%	**2.3%**[2024]	−22.7 pp ▼	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#50	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	0.0%	**2.4%**[2024]	+2.4 pp ▲	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#50	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	30%	**6.8%**[2024]	−23.2 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#49	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	25%	**20%**[2025]	−5.2 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#42	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$41.4K	**$51.4K**[2025]	+24% ▲	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#38	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	519	**650**[2024]	+25% ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#49	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	0.0%	**0.0%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#49	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	249	**480**[2024]	+93% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#50	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	0.0%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#50	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#47	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.0%	**0.0%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#50	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.0%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#50	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.0%	**0.0%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#46	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	37	**78**[2026]	–	127K	+14% ▲	#48	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	13	**95**[2026]	–	268K	+52% ▲	#49	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.0%	**0.1%**[2026]	0.0 pp	–	–	#48	[13]
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	2.6%	**3.7%**[2026]	+1.1 pp ▲	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#20	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	54%	**28%**[2026]	−25.8 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#11	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	5.4%	**12%**[2026]	+6.1 pp ▲	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#45	[13]
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	78%	**50%**[2026]	−28.4 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#11	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							
Workers in STEM occupations	21.9K	**35.1K**[2024]	+60% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#46	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	4.4%	**6.1%**[2024]	+1.6 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#42	[12]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

MONTANA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION (CONTINUED)							
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	1.8%	**2.4%**[2024]	+0.6 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#51	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	1.1%	**1.2%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#51	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	0.2%	**0.1%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#51	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	2.1%	**2.8%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#50	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	4.3%	**6.6%**[2025]	+2.2 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#49	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	22.9K	**28.6K**[2025]	+25% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#46	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.86	**0.84**[2025]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#34	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$62.6K	**$90.5K**[2025]	+44% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#49	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$83K[2019]	**$122K**[2025]	+47% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#36	[10]
Software developer jobs	1.25K	**2.16K**[2025]	+73% ▲	1.69M	+48% ▲	#45	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal, nominal dollars	$40.6K	**$60.9K**[2025]	+50% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#38	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	52	**233**[2025]	4.47× ▲	135K	−0.6% ▼	#39	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	0.0%	**0.2%**[2025]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#39	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	5.8%	**71%**[2025]	+65.0 pp ▲	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#1	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	31%	**9.0%**[2025]	−21.8 pp ▼	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#45	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	0.0%	**0.0%**[2025]	0.0 pp	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#44	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	12%	**10%**[2025]	−1.9 pp ▼	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#37	[22]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

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